

天命輓歌

Elegy of the Mandate

天命
輓歌

第一回 桃林結義 玄圭出世

桃花血色結三義

玄圭寒光照九爐

話說九爐之世，天地猶未定形，諸侯割據，各擅山川之利。鐵城永邑居九爐之中，城牆高可摩雲，爐火晝夜不熄，鑄甲三千，威震四方。其主吳烈，身長九尺，面如玄鐵，目若炬火，自幼從征，未嘗一敗。世人皆稱之曰：「永邑之虎，天下無雙。」然盛名之下，民心未必盡服。是歲夏末，城中糧賦加重，徭役不休，市井之間，怨聲隱隱如地底悶雷，積而待發。

CHAPTER 1: BROTHERHOOD SWORN IN THE PEACH GROVE; THE DARK OMEN COMES INTO THE WORLD

Peach blossoms, blood-red, bind three sworn souls

The dark jade gleams cold across the Nine Furnaces

In the age of the Nine Furnaces, when heaven and earth had not yet settled into fixed form, the lords of the realm divided the mountains and rivers among themselves, each grasping what advantage the land afforded. The iron city of Yong stood at the heart of the Nine Furnaces: its walls rose high enough to graze the clouds, its furnace-fires burned without ceasing through day and night, it had forged three thousand suits of armour, and its might awed the four quarters. Its lord, Wu Lie, stood nine feet tall, his face dark as cast iron, his eyes bright as torchfire. From childhood he had gone on campaigns, and he had never once been defeated. The people of the world called him thus: 'The tiger of Yong — without equal under heaven.' Yet beneath such renown, the hearts of the common people were not entirely won. In the last weeks of that summer, the grain levies in the city had been doubled, corvée labour went without rest, and through the lanes and markets a murmur of resentment gathered — like thunder suppressed beneath the earth, accumulating, waiting to break.

一日，東市徵糧官強奪寡婦陳氏之粟，婦人哭號於街，旁觀者皆側目而不敢言。忽一壯漢自人群中躍出，身著獸皮，髮如亂草，赤足踏地，聲若洪鐘，喝道：「官府橫行，天理何在！」一拳打翻徵糧小吏，眾人嘩然。此人乃璟同，野生之士，自幼長於永邑城外雲嵐山中，與獸為伍，不識禮法，然天生神力，義膽包天。消息傳至吳烈耳中，烈大怒，親率甲士趕赴東市，欲拿此人問罪。

鐵蹄踏碎青石街，殺氣橫掃市中天。

野人立地如山嶽，虎目圓睜不肯遷。

二虎相逢爭王氣，長街盡頭是血緣。

One day, a grain-collection officer in the Eastern Market seized by force the millet of a widow named Chen. The woman wailed in the street; bystanders averted their eyes and dared not speak. Suddenly a powerfully built man leapt from the crowd. He wore hides of wild animals; his hair was tangled as weeds; he went barefoot on the earth; and his voice rang out like a great bell: 'When officials run rampant, where does Heaven's reason go?' With one fist he knocked the grain clerk flat. The crowd erupted in uproar. This man was Jing Tong — a wild-born warrior, raised since childhood in the Cloud-Mist Mountains outside the walls of Yong, companion to beasts, ignorant of ritual propriety, yet endowed from birth with godlike strength and a righteousness vast as the sky. Word reached Wu Lie's ears, and Wu Lie was enraged. He led armoured soldiers personally to the Eastern Market, intending to seize this man and call him to account.

Iron hooves shatter the cobblestone street; a killing air sweeps the sky above the market.

The wild man stands upon the earth like a mountain, tiger-eyes wide open, refusing to yield.

Two tigers meet and contend for kingly breath — at the far end of the long street, blood ties wait.

吳烈至，見璟同獨立塵埃之中，神色從容，四周甲士已將其圍困。烈喝令拿下，璟同卻仰天長笑，答曰：「天下英雄，我未嘗服過一人。汝既是永邑之主，且來較量。」吳烈聞言，怒火中燒，卻又隱覺此人氣度非凡，乃捥退左右，親自下馬，以拳腳相搏。兩人廝打半日，街石皆碎，屋瓦俱震。吳烈一生征戰，從未遭逢對手，此番竟與一野人打成平手。日暮時分，二人皆立而喘，互視良久，相顧大笑。吳烈心中某處忽然鬆動，如久封之閘門，洪水欲

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此一「鬆動」二字，寫盡英雄遇知己之微妙。鐵石心腸，逢璟同而始柔，此後悲劇之根，已種於此笑中矣。批者淚下。

Wu Lie arrived to find Jing Tong standing alone amid the dust, his bearing composed, surrounded already by armoured soldiers on all sides. Wu Lie shouted the order to seize him; but Jing Tong threw back his head and laughed aloud at the sky, answering: 'Among all the heroes under heaven, I have yet to submit to a single one. Since you are the lord of Yong, come and let us measure ourselves.' Hearing this, Wu Lie's anger blazed up — yet he sensed at once that this man's bearing was extraordinary. He waved his soldiers back, dismounted himself, and they fought with fists and feet. The two men grappled for half a day; the paving stones cracked, the roof-tiles shook. Wu Lie had fought wars his entire life and never encountered a match — yet now, against a wild-born man, he had been fought to a standstill. At dusk the two stood panting, facing each other for a long moment, then looked at one another and burst out laughing together. Something in Wu Lie's chest suddenly loosened, as a floodgate long sealed gives way before onrushing water. These two characters — 'loosened' — capture perfectly the subtle tremor of a hero meeting his true companion. An iron heart softens only upon meeting Jing Tong; the seeds of all later tragedy are already planted within this laugh. The commentator's tears fall.

自此，吳烈不再問璟同之罪，反延之入府，以上賓待之。然府中食衣皆有規制，璟同百般不慣，常赤膊奔走庭院，引得侍從掩口而笑。軍師昭明者，永邑謀主也，面白如玉，目光深遠如秋水。昭明初見璟同，撫掌曰：「此天降之將，非俗世所能羈束，主公得此人，如虎添翼矣。」三人相處日久，情義漸深，吳烈嘗於獨處時歎曰：「吾征戰半生，朋友無幾，孰知於一街市之鬥中，得此二人。」

From that day forward, Wu Lie no longer sought to punish Jing Tong; instead he invited him into the manor and received him as a guest of honour. Yet the manor's food and clothing all followed prescribed forms, and Jing Tong found nothing to his liking. He would often run through the courtyards bare-chested, causing the attendants to cover their mouths and laugh. The strategist Zhao Ming, master counsellor of Yong, had a face white as jade and eyes of deep and distant clarity, like autumn water. When Zhao Ming first laid eyes on Jing Tong, he clapped his hands together and said: 'This is a general sent down by Heaven — no ordinary world can bind him. My lord, in gaining this man, you are a tiger given wings.' As the three men spent more days together, the bonds of feeling and loyalty deepened. Wu Lie would sometimes sigh in private moments: 'Half my life I have fought wars and had few friends — who could have known that in a street-market brawl I would find these two men?'

是年中秋之後，永邑城西三十里有桃林一片，桃樹數百株，秋意已深，葉落殆盡，唯枯枝橫斜，然其間時有晚桃數朵，殘紅猶艷，如血珠綴於銀枝之上。吳烈召昭明、璟同至此，設牛酒，鋪黃土，三人跪伏，各刺指血，滴於同一盞酒中，仰天盟誓。昭明代三人立誓詞，辭曰：「吾三人雖非同年同月同日生，但願同心共力，扶危救困，不負天地，不負此生。有渝此誓，天地共殛之。」誓畢，三人飲血酒，擲盞於地，盞碎聲中，彼此相視，淚光隱

After the Mid-Autumn of that year, thirty li west of the city of Yong there lay a grove of peach trees — several hundred trees in all. The autumn had already deepened, the leaves had mostly fallen, and only bare branches crossed the air at angles; yet here and there late peach blossoms still opened in ones and twos, their fading crimson still vivid, like drops of blood strung upon silver branches. Wu Lie summoned Zhao Ming and Jing Tong to this place. He set out an ox and wine, spread yellow earth upon the ground, and the three men knelt and bowed. Each pricked a finger, letting blood fall into the same cup of wine. They lifted their faces to heaven and swore an oath. Zhao Ming composed the vow on behalf of all three: 'Though we three were not born in the same year, the same month, or the same day, we vow to be of one mind and united strength — to support the endangered, to relieve the suffering, never to betray heaven and earth, never to betray this life. Should any of us break this oath, let heaven and earth together strike him down.' The oath was spoken; the three men drank the blood-wine; they flung the cup to the ground; in the crack of its shattering they looked at one another, and a glimmer of tears showed in every eye.

殘桃幾朵綴枯枝，血酒同飲誓難移。

昭明執筆書盟約，環同仰天淚不知。

吳烈此生多鐵骨，今日方識柔腸時。

桃林風起花如雨，三魂從此結一絲。

「一絲」者，情之細而難斷也。作者於此用「絲」而不用「繩」，蓋絲者易斷而斷之最痛，一字藏盡後文環同之死與吳烈之哭。讀者不可輕過。

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永邑卷一之東，有苑名曰朱華苑，乃吳烈命人廣植花木所築，曲廊迴環，池水清

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澈，四時花開不絕。苑中最奇者，乃一株古梅，樹齡逾三百年，幹若虬龍，花時香氣可傳十里。吳烈每於征戰歸來，必先入此苑，獨坐片刻，方能重歸人間之態。苑中有一女，名喚雲素華，乃孤女出身，自幼入苑，工詩善書，性情幽靜如深水。她每日持筆記錄苑中一切，花開幾朵，葉落幾片，偶有外間消息傳入，亦一一錄於簿冊之中。眾人皆知其名，然見其人者少，如苑中那株古梅，默然自存。

A few spent blossoms cling to bare branches; blood-wine drunk together — the vow will not shift.
Zhao Ming takes the brush and writes the covenant; Jing Tong throws back his face to heaven,
unaware of tears.

Wu Lie's life has been all iron and bone — only today does he learn the hour when tenderness
comes.

Wind rises in the peach grove and blossoms fall like rain; three souls are from this moment bound
by a single thread.

The word 'thread' — fine yet unbreakable in feeling. The author here writes 'thread' rather than 'rope': a thread is easily severed, and yet its severing is the most agonising. In this single word the death of Jing Tong and the weeping of Wu Lie are entirely concealed. The reader must not pass lightly over this.

To the east of Yong lay a garden known as the Vermilion Garden, which Wu Lie had ordered planted with broad expanses of flowers and trees. Winding covered walkways circled in on themselves; the pool water ran clear; flowers opened without ceasing through all four seasons. The most wondrous thing in the garden was an ancient plum tree, more than three hundred years old, its trunk twisted like a coiling dragon; when it bloomed its fragrance could carry ten li. Every time Wu Lie returned from a campaign, he would first enter this garden and sit alone for a time before he could resume a human bearing. Within the garden there lived a young woman named Yun Suhua — of orphaned origin, she had entered the garden from childhood, excelling in poetry and accomplished in calligraphy, her temperament still and deep as a well. Each day she took up her brush and recorded everything in the garden: how many flowers had opened, how many leaves had fallen; and when occasional news from the outside world reached her, she recorded that too, item by item, in her ledgers. Everyone in the manor knew her name, yet few had actually seen her — like that ancient plum tree in the garden, she existed in silent self-containment.

桃林結義之日，雲素華身在朱華苑，自不曾親睹，然訊息傳回之時，她手中筆不曾停，於簿中寫下數行。其字跡細如蚊足，然字字清晰如刀刻。她寫道：「是日，城西桃林，三人結義。一為永邑之主，剛烈如火；一為謀士，冷靜如冰；一為野人，渾然如山。火與山相逢，城不燃而更危，此非佳兆也。吾恐此後，朱華苑中，歡笑漸少，墨痕漸多。」書罷，擱筆，窗外梅花忽落一瓣，無風自墮，輕飄飄落入硯中，染墨半片，如淚痕。

素華此語，是全書

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之眼也。火烈者吳烈，山渾者環同，二人相合不相毀，其力反大，故禍更深。作者借女子之筆，道破天機，而女子獨知，男兒不

聞，此世間常態，令人哀也。

素華獨坐窗前夜，
燈影搖搖字亦斜。
苑外歡聲傳義氣，
苑中墨淚潤梅花。

On the day the oath was sworn in the peach grove, Yun Suhua was in the Vermilion Garden and had not witnessed it herself; yet when news was carried back, her brush in hand never paused. She wrote several lines in her ledger. Her characters were thin as mosquito-feet, yet each one was clear as if cut by a knife. She wrote: 'On this day, in the peach grove west of the city, three men swore brotherhood. One is the lord of Yong, fierce and ardent as fire; one is a counsellor, still and cool as ice; one is a wild-born man, whole and uncut as a mountain. When fire meets mountain, the city does not burn — and yet the danger is greater. This is not a good omen. I fear that hereafter, within the Vermilion Garden, laughter will grow fewer and traces of ink more numerous.' When she had finished writing, she set down her brush. Outside the window a plum petal fell — falling of itself without wind — and drifted down into the inkstone, staining half of it with ink, like the track of a tear. These words of Suhua are the eye of the entire book. Wu Lie is the ardent fire; Jing Tong is the whole mountain. When two such forces unite without destroying each other, their combined power is greater still — and therefore the catastrophe runs deeper. The author uses a woman's brush to pierce through to heaven's secret, yet the woman alone perceives it while the men hear nothing. This is the common condition of the world — and cause enough for grief.

Suhua sits alone before her window in the night; the lamp's shadow wavers, and her characters lean.

Outside the garden, sounds of joy carry the breath of brotherhood; within, ink-tears moisten the plum blossoms.

卻說九爐之世，除諸侯紛爭之外，另有一物，乃天下覬覦之所在，名曰天命璽。此璽以崑崙玄玉所制，通體幽黑，刻山河萬里之紋，持之者如握天下之重，輕則三百斤。璽本供奉於九爐居中之靈嶽——玄樞山之頂，由三族共守，號稱中立之物，諸侯無論勝負，皆不得擅取。然璽之存在，本身即是禍因，天下人皆知持璽者天命所歸，故覬覦之心，百年不絕。是時玄樞山守璽之三族，已因瑣事生隙，各懷疑心，守備漸弛。吳烈聞之，曾密告昭明曰：

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「若易主，天下必亂。」昭明撚須沉思，良久曰：「亂，本已在途中。」

Yet in the age of the Nine Furnaces, beyond the struggles of the lords, there existed one object that all the world coveted: the Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate. This seal had been fashioned from the dark jade of the Kunlun Mountains. Its entire body was of a deep, still black, engraved with the patterns of mountains and rivers for ten thousand li. Whoever held it held what felt like the full weight of the world in their hands — no lighter than three hundred catties. The Seal had been enshrined at the summit of Xuanshu Mountain — the Spirit Peak at the heart of the Nine Furnaces — jointly guarded by three clans, proclaimed a neutral object: whatever the outcome of any lord's victory or defeat, none might seize it unilaterally. Yet the very existence of the Seal was itself a cause of calamity, for all under heaven knew that whoever held the Seal had heaven's mandate conferred upon them; and so the desire to possess it had gone unextinguished for a hundred years. At this time the three clans guarding the Seal on Xuanshu Mountain had already fallen into friction over minor matters, each harbouring suspicion of the others, and their vigilance had gradually slackened. Wu Lie, hearing of this, once privately informed Zhao Ming: 'If the Seal changes hands, the realm will certainly fall into chaos.' Zhao Ming stroked his beard in deep thought, and after a long silence said: 'Chaos — is already on its way.'

朱華苑之設，原為吳烈平生難得之溫柔鄉，苑中有荷池、梅塢、竹徑、菊圃，四時景致各異。璟同初入苑中，見滿目繁花，竟呆立半晌，喃喃曰：「我在山中二十年，從未見此物。」吳烈笑道：「此後苑便是你的，想何時來便何時來。」璟同聞言，赧然低頭，指尖輕觸一朵半開的朱槿，輕聲道：「如此嬌弱，真不知如何是好。」吳烈立於其側，望之良久，心中隱生一種從未有過的暖意，如冬日爐火，悄悄映亮一室。

鐵人入苑識芳菲，低首輕觸朱槿枝。

一世殺伐不知柔，今朝苑中始學遲。

吳烈旁觀心已亂，此暖從來不知歸。

The Vermilion Garden had been established as a rare and cherished refuge of tenderness in Wu Lie's life. Within it were a lotus pond, a plum-tree hollow, bamboo-lined paths, and chrysanthemum beds, each season offering its own distinct scene. The first time Jing Tong entered the garden, he stood motionless for a long while at the sight of flowers filling his view on every side, murmuring: 'I lived in the mountains for twenty years and never saw such things.' Wu Lie laughed and said: 'From now on the garden is yours — come whenever you please.' Hearing this, Jing Tong ducked his head, a flush of feeling in his face, and touched the tip of one finger to a half-open red hibiscus blossom, saying softly: 'Something so delicate — I truly don't know how to treat it.' Wu Lie stood at his side and watched him for a long moment, and in his heart there grew, quietly, a warmth he had never felt before — like a winter hearth-fire, gently illuminating an entire room.

An iron man enters the garden and learns what fragrance is; he bows his head to touch the red hibiscus branch.

A lifetime of killing and war, never knowing softness — only now, in the garden, does he begin to learn, and slowly.

Wu Lie watches from the side, his heart already unsettled; this warmth — he has never known before where it might go.

燈花爆裂，室中一暗，素華對影獨坐，心中隱有所感，難以名狀。

是夜，雲素華於燈下覽舊簿，見往年所錄苑事，字字如昨，心中感慨，又提筆添錄今日之事：「璟同入苑，如山入水，兩相映照，竟成奇景。吳烈性烈，璟同性野，然二者相處，竟有難言之默契，如天成。昭明在旁，面有微笑，然笑中有算，算中有憂，憂而不言。吾今日見此三人，忽想起幼時所讀古語：二火相遇，不燃則熄。二人皆是火，惟不知燃者何物，熄者何時。苑中梅樹今夜落瓣尤多，不知何故，拾得數瓣，置於書中留存。」記畢，合燈前合簿夜已深，梅瓣書中藏幾春。

素華默坐無言語，紙上英雄紙上人。

明日戰鼓或又響，苑中誰解此時心。

That night, Yun Suhua reviewed old ledgers by lamplight, reading what had been recorded in past years about the garden's affairs — each character fresh as yesterday — and feeling much move within her. She lifted her brush again and added the day's entry: 'Jing Tong entered the garden today, as a mountain enters water; the two reflecting each other formed a strange and striking scene. Wu Lie's nature is fierce; Jing Tong's nature is wild; yet the two of them together possess an unspoken accord that seems natural as if heaven-made. Zhao Ming stood to the side with a slight smile on his face — yet within the smile there was calculation, and within the calculation, anxiety; anxious, and yet saying nothing. Seeing these three men today, I suddenly recalled an old saying I read in childhood: Two fires when they meet will either flare up or go out. Both men are fire; I only do not know what it is that will burn, nor when it will be extinguished. The plum tree in the garden shed an unusually large number of petals tonight — I do not know why. I gathered several and placed them in the book for safekeeping.' When the entry was complete, she closed the ledger. The lamp-flower burst and crackled; the room dimmed for a moment. Suhua sat alone facing her own shadow, with something stirring in her heart that had no name.

Before the lamp she closes the ledger; the night has deepened; plum petals tucked in the book hold
how many springs.

Suhua sits silent with no words to speak — heroes on paper, people on paper.

Tomorrow the war-drums may sound again; within the garden, who could understand this
moment's heart.

欲知後事如何，且看下回分解。天命璽既存於世，玄樞山守備日弛，而諸侯之野心，從未一日止息。朱華苑中，三人義氣初結，笑語猶溫，然素華筆下之憂，已如伏流潛行於地。世事之轉，往往不在鐘鼓齊鳴之時，而在一枚花瓣無聲落入硯中之際。讀者諸君，且將此一笑、此一淚、此一瓣梅花，一齊收入心底，以待後章之驗。正是：兩火相遇，城未燃而憂先至；三義初成，苑尤在而人將散。

As for what happened next, the following chapter will reveal all. The Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate remained in the world; the defences of Xuanshu Mountain grew slacker day by day; and the ambitions of the lords had never ceased for a single day. Within the Vermilion Garden, the bonds of brotherhood among the three men had just been forged, their laughter and warmth still fresh — yet the anxiety traced by Suhua's brush already moved like an underground current flowing unseen beneath the earth. The turning of worldly affairs so often comes not in the moment of drums and bells sounding together, but in the instant when a single petal falls in silence into an inkstone. Gentle readers: take this one laugh, this one tear, this one plum petal, and gather them all into the depths of your heart, to await their verification in the chapters to come. As it truly is: Two fires meet — the city has not yet burned, yet sorrow arrives first. The three-part brotherhood is newly formed — the garden still stands, yet the people will soon be scattered.

第二回 天樞失璽 九土鼎沸

一璽離天樞夜墮

九爐沸四海朝驚

卻說天樞祠立於九爐河心之洲，四水環抱，煙嵐不散，自開闢以來，天命璽藏於其中，諸侯歲貢香火，無敢窺者。祠中道士三十六人，晨鐘暮鼓，守之如命。是夜，月色如霜，河聲入夢，唯有一葉輕舟橫渡無聲。

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霧胤者，其國舊稱輝澤，世傳天命璽本為輝澤先君所鑄，後因諸侯爭奪，暫付天樞祠公守。霧胤少負詩才，然胸藏大志，嘗獨坐江樓，撫琴而歌曰：「璽者，天之所屬，豈得長委草野祠官之手？」其師諫之，霧胤笑而不答，目中有星火之光。

此一筆寫霧胤，非惡人，乃錯執之人。星火者，可燎原，亦可自焚。

CHAPTER 2: THE POLE-STAR LOSES ITS SEAL; THE NINE LANDS BOIL OVER

One seal quits the Pole-Star shrine and falls through the night

Nine furnaces boil; at dawn the four seas start awake

Now it is told: the Pole-Star Shrine stood upon an isle in the middle waters of the Nine Furnaces, girdled by four confluent streams, its mists unbroken since the world's making. Within it the Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate had rested since the age of origins, and the lords of every polity sent incense-tribute by season; none had dared covet it with open eyes. Thirty-six Taoist priests kept the shrine, morning bell and evening drum, guarding it as they guarded their own lives. That night the moonlight lay white as hoarfrost, the river's voice stole into dreams, and one small boat crossed without a sound.

Wu Yin, prince of the old realm of Huize, had been taught since childhood that the Jade Seal was first cast by Huize's ancestral lord, and had been surrendered to the Shrine only as a provisional custody during an age of contention. Wu Yin bore a poet's gifts from youth yet harbored ambitions vast as the river-bends. He would sit alone in his riverside tower, plucking his zither, singing to himself: 'The seal is Heaven's own property — how long may it moulder in the hands of grass-court shrine-keepers?' When his advisors remonstrated, Wu Yin smiled and said nothing, and in his eyes there burned the small fierce light of a star. This single stroke portrays Wu Yin: not a villain but a man who grasps wrongly. Starfire can sweep the plain or consume the hand that holds it.

輕舟入夜水無痕

袖裡乾坤藏萬鈞

我本天家舊血胤

奪還非盜是歸真

月冷不知人意熱

霧深偏讓膽氣伸

一
天
命
輓
歌
▼
卷
二
一
握
河
山
皆
可
問

誰言命數不由身

A light skiff enters night and leaves no mark upon the water
Within his sleeve a cosmos holds ten-thousand catties' weight
I am the true-born blood of Heaven's ancient household
To take back what is mine is not theft but a homecoming
The cold moon does not know how hot the purpose of men burns
Deep fog only gives bold breath more room to stretch and rise
With one grip all the mountains and rivers may be questioned
Who says the count of fate is not a thing the self may steer

霧胤登岸，衣袂沾露，步入祠門，守門道士正伏案假寐。彼以袖拂燈，燈滅。黑暗中但聞自己心跳之聲，如戰鼓遠來。摸索至內殿，璽置玉几，光華隱隱，似有靈識。霧胤俯身，雙手捧璽，感其溫潤如活物，心中一震，默立良久，方納入懷，轉身出祠，重登輕舟，竟無一人覺醒。天色將明，霧散一半，彼遙望天樞洲漸遠，低聲吟道：「璽歸故主，天理昭然。」然其聲微顫，不似自信。

天光大亮，祠中道士醒來，見玉几空空，璽印不存，失聲大叫。主持道人面如死灰，顫手敲動洪鐘，鐘聲震盪九爐，鳴不止聲。頃刻，洲南烽火台燃起第一柱狼煙，高入雲霄；繼而東岸、西岸、北渚諸台相繼點燃，煙柱如林，直刺天際。沿河百里，信使縱馬疾馳，口中只一句話：「天命璽失！天命璽失！」

Wu Yin stepped ashore, his sleeves damp with dew, and walked through the shrine gate. The keeper dozing at his post never stirred. Wu Yin brushed his sleeve past a lamp and the flame died. In the darkness he heard only his own heartbeat, like a battle-drum approaching from far away. He felt his way to the inner hall. The Seal sat upon its jade table, its luminescence a dim and breathing thing, as though it possessed awareness. Wu Yin bent low and cupped it in both hands; it was warm and smooth as a living creature, and at its touch something struck his chest like a mallet. He stood motionless a long moment, then tucked it into his robe, turned, left the shrine, stepped again into his small boat, and departed — and not one soul woke. Dawn was near. The mist had half withdrawn. He looked back at the Isle of the Pole-Star receding behind him and murmured: 'The seal returns to its rightful master; the principle of Heaven is made plain.' But his voice held the faintest tremor, and it did not sound like certainty.

When full daylight came and the priests of the shrine awoke, they found the jade table empty and the Seal gone. A shout of anguish broke from one throat, then all. The head priest's face turned the color of ash; with trembling hands he struck the great bronze bell, and its voice shook across the Nine Furnaces without ceasing. Within moments the signal tower at the isle's southern tip lit its first column of wolf-smoke, driving straight into the clouds; then the eastern bank towers, the western bank towers, the northern shallows towers — one after another they flared until smoke-pillars stood thick as a forest, stabbing the sky. For a hundred li along the river, couriers drove their horses to exhaustion, and from every mouth came a single sentence: 'The Seal of Heaven's Mandate is lost! The Seal of Heaven's Mandate is lost!'

訊息既傳，九爐震動。諸侯或驚或懼，或竊喜，或憤怒，人心各異，如沸鍋中諸物翻滾。霧胤返國，召百官，陳璽於廟堂，宣告天命歸輝澤，文武皆伏地叩首，歡呼聲震瓦礫。南鄰夔渚之主觀望三日，計利而降；西方平壑侯懼輝澤兵鋒，遣使納貢，口稱臣服。然餘下六邦，聞訊皆憤，以為霧胤此舉乃以竊盜代信義，以強力易公理，若任其坐實，則天下無公道可言。

尺，眉如墨弧，目若寒星，平日不多言而言必中要。聞璽失之訊，彼三日不食，第四日起身，披甲而立，語眾曰：「竊來之命，非命也，乃賊也。吾輩非為諸侯私利而戰，乃為天下之公義而戰。」眾皆服其言。昭明居其後，手持輿圖，默而不語，唯眼中光芒流動如計算之火。

When the news spread, the Nine Furnaces shook. The lords of each polity reacted according to their natures — some in shock, some in dread, some in secret satisfaction, some in outrage — and the hearts of men churned like various things tumbling in a boiling pot. Wu Yin returned to his realm, summoned his hundred officials, displayed the Seal in the great hall, and proclaimed that Heaven's Mandate had come home to Huize. Civil and military officers all prostrated themselves; the shouts of acclamation rattled the roof-tiles. The lord of Kuizhu to the south watched and calculated for three days before submitting to the new legitimacy. The Marquis of Pinghe to the west, fearing the edge of Huize's armies, sent envoys bearing tribute and mouthing the words of submission. But the remaining six realms, on hearing the news, were furious to a man. They held that Wu Yin's act had replaced faith with theft and exchanged justice for brute force, and that if it were allowed to harden into fact, there would be no such thing as principle left under Heaven.

The six realms convened at Hunjian Ford, smeared their lips with blood, and took a common oath. They named Wu Lie, lord of Yong, as the alliance's war-fist. Wu Lie stood eight feet tall, his brows dark as brushed ink, his eyes cold as winter stars; in ordinary days he spoke rarely, but when he spoke he struck the center of things. When news of the Seal's theft reached him, he did not eat for three days. On the fourth morning he rose, buckled on his armor, and stood before his people. 'A mandate stolen is no mandate,' he said. 'It is only larceny. We do not fight for the private advantage of any lord; we fight for the public justice of All-under-Heaven.' Every man who heard him was persuaded. Zhao Ming stood behind him, map in hand, saying nothing, only his eyes moving with the bright restless motion of a flame performing calculations.

昭明夜燃孤燈，俯案推演，以沙盤布陣，以竹籌計糧。天明時分，戰策已成，呈於吳烈。其略有三：一曰截糧，斷輝澤南路補給；二曰離間，使夔渚、平壑心生疑懼；三曰聲東，佯攻東渡而實取北渚要塞。吳烈覽畢，合圖而笑，曰：「昭明之算，如弈者觀枰，勝負已在未動之先。」璟同在旁，撫掌大笑，請為前鋒。

怖。

此語看似稱讚昭明，實則伏筆：未動之先已算定者，亦包括璟同之死。昭明算得準，故最可

Zhao Ming burned his solitary lamp through the night, bent over the table, laying out formations in the sand-tray, calculating provisions with bamboo tallies. By dawn the campaign design was finished and presented to Wu Lie. Its principles were three: first, to cut supply lines and sever Huize's southern provisioning routes; second, to sow suspicion between Kuizhu and Pinghe until their allegiance to Wu Yin curdled with doubt; third, a feint eastward at the river crossing while the true blow fell on the northern shallows fortress. Wu Lie read it through, closed the map, and smiled. 'Zhao Ming's reckoning,' he said, 'is like a chess-master reading the board — the outcome is already settled before a single piece has moved.' Jing Tong, standing nearby, clapped his hands with a great laugh and asked to lead the vanguard. This phrase praises Zhao Ming on its surface, yet it plants a hidden root: what is settled before a piece moves includes Jing Tong's death. Zhao Ming calculates correctly — and that is precisely what makes him terrible.

永邑鐵騎三萬整

旌旗蔽日動雷聲

淵沼之師持長戟

雲台舊部耀銀盃

瀧口弓手八千勁

善射者能穿楊枝

霜崖劍客輕生死

天命輓歌

卷三

踏歌入陣血為詞

The iron cavalry of Yong comes thirty thousand strong and whole
Banners blot the sun; the sound of it moves like pealing thunder
The marsh-water army advances bearing long-hafted halberds
The old soldiers of Cloud-Terrace burnish their silver helmets bright
Eight thousand bowmen of the Cascade Gate — their draw is taut and fierce
The finest among them can split a willow-leaf at racing speed
The sword-wanderers of Frost Cliff hold their lives at less than nothing
They enter the formation singing, and blood becomes their lyric

東路來者橫江騎

坐騎皆為河西馬

北師步卒如密林

矛尖映天寒如鏡

輜重車行壓道沉

糧秣萬石備三年

旗下謀士各懷算

天命輓歌

卷二

無人問璽歸誰家

From the eastern road the river-crossing cavalry arrives
Every mount among them is bred from the horses west of the river
The northern infantry is dense as a forest in autumn
Their spearpoints catch the sky and give it back as cold as mirrors
Supply-carts press the road down deep with their laden passage
Ten thousand shi of grain and fodder — provisions for three years
Under every banner counselors nurse their private calculations
Not one of them thinks to ask which house the Seal belongs to

中流鼓聲震九天

水師千舸齊解纜

槳聲咿呀入雲去

浪花濺甲白如練

環同立艚持大旗

笑問東風可借否

吳烈背手望遠山

天命輓歌

卷二

昭明閉目已知路

是時，天下共言戰事，然於輝澤宮中，霧胤獨坐書房，展素紙，磨墨，提筆欲作詩，卻久久不落。窗外春風搖動桃花，花瓣如雪飄入硯中，染紅了一角。霧胤凝視良久，終書四字而止：「我非竊者。」復又凝視此四字，眉頭漸蹙，終以袖拭去，紙上留一片墨痕，模糊如未定之命。

In midstream the war-drums shake the nine-layered sky
The water-army looses a thousand vessels from their moorings at once
The sound of oars rises creaking into cloud
Spray beats the armor white as lengths of silk
Jing Tong stands at the prow and holds the great flag upright
He laughs and asks: may we borrow the east wind today
Wu Lie stands with hands clasped behind him, watching the far mountains
Zhao Ming closes his eyes — he already knows the road

At this time all the world spoke of war; yet in the inner library of the Huize palace, Wu Yin sat alone. He unrolled clean paper, ground his ink, lifted his brush to write — and could not bring it down. Outside the window the spring wind shook the peach blossoms, and petals like snow drifted in and fell into his inkstone, staining one corner red. Wu Yin stared at this for a long time. At last he wrote four characters and stopped: 'I am not a thief.' Then he stared at those four characters, and the furrow between his brows deepened by degrees, until he wiped the line away with his sleeve. The paper kept the ghost of the ink, blurred and irresolute as a fate not yet decided.

消息沿河傳至永邑深院，雲素華正倚欄觀魚，侍女來報諸事，素華靜聽，一語不發。待侍女退去，彼緩緩取出竹冊，以細筆記錄諸事：璽失之日，煙火之狀，各邦之應，吳烈之誓，昭明之謀，璟同之笑。記畢，輕輕合冊，望天色，低語：「開戰了。」其聲如水沉入河底，無漣漪，無回聲。

吳烈臨行前，立於旗下，仰觀天色，見烏雲自西北來，隱隱有雷聲未發。左

右問是否出師，吳烈答曰：「戰事一起，九爐之水皆變顏色。然我心中有一

事未明——那璽，究竟是天之所命，還是人之所造？若為人造，則奪之者，何異於奪一塊頑玉？」昭明在旁，低聲答：「主公此問，待戰畢再答，今日只問勝負。」吳烈沉默，終點頭，出師。

The news traveled along the river and reached the deep courtyards of Yong. Yun Suhua was leaning on the balustrade watching the fish when a maidservant came and reported everything. Suhua listened without a word. When the maidservant withdrew, she reached slowly for her bamboo record-book and with a fine brush wrote down what had come to pass: the day the Seal was lost; the shape of the smoke-fires; how each realm responded; the oath Wu Lie had sworn; the design Zhao Ming had devised; the laugh Jing Tong had given. When it was recorded she closed the book gently, looked at the sky, and whispered: 'The war has begun.' Her voice was like water sinking to the bottom of a river — no ripple, no echo.

Before he departed, Wu Lie stood beneath the great banner and looked up at the sky. Dark clouds were moving down from the northwest, and somewhere in the distance thunder was forming but had not yet spoken. Those around him asked whether it was time to set out. Wu Lie answered: 'Once battle begins, the waters of the Nine Furnaces will all change color. Yet there is one thing in my heart that remains unclear — the Seal: is it something Heaven decreed, or something men made? If men made it, then whoever takes it by force — how is that different from seizing a worthless stone?' Zhao Ming, standing beside him, answered in a low voice: 'That question, my lord, can wait until the fighting is done. Today we ask only about victory and defeat.' Wu Lie was silent a moment. Then he nodded, and the army went forth.

璽失天心搖九州

義旗所指血未收

昭明籌算秋毫密

璟同笑聲渡急流

吳烈誓言重如嶽

霧胤詩稿墨難留

天命輓歌
素華默記春與戰

史筆無情兩鬢秋

The Seal is lost and the heart of Heaven rocks across the nine provinces
Where the banner of righteousness points the blood has not yet dried
Zhao Ming's calculations are as fine and dense as autumn down
Jing Tong's laughter carries him across the racing current
Wu Lie's oath weighs upon the world as mountains weigh upon the earth
Wu Yin's poem-drafts hold ink that will not stay
Suhua records in silence both the spring and the war
The historian's brush knows no mercy — on both temples, autumn

第三回 朱華秋讌 詩讖先成

金菊含秋淚未乾

玉人對影問誰憐

卻說九鼎之亂既起，烽火連天，吳烈、昭明諸君子皆從徵於北疆，朱華苑中惟餘諸女眷相守。時值深秋，菊花盛放，黃白紫赤，遍佈廊階池畔。雲素華染疾已久，面色如紙，然目光澄澈，猶如秋水照天，獨居翠微閣，日夕臨窗望雁。

天命輓歌

卷三

二十二

是日，諸姊妹共議，言菊花正盛，不可辜負，遂邀雲素華並眾人於芙蓉榭設秋讌，行菊花詩令。規矩既定：各擬一題，題中須有菊字，依韻填詞，詞成方可飲酒。雲素華應邀而來，著月白羅裙，披淡青薄氈，扶侍女之手，緩步而至，落座於池畔石凳，笑曰：「諸姊若以詩令相罰，素華本是重病之人，飲不得半盞，只怕輸得最慘。」眾人皆笑，秋風起處，菊香四溢。

CHAPTER 3: AUTUMN FEAST IN THE VERMILION GARDEN; THE VERSE-OMENS ARE WRITTEN FIRST

Golden chrysanthemums hold autumn tears not yet dried

The jade lady faces a shadow and asks — who will pity her?

Now it is told: since the turmoil of the Nine Furnaces had erupted and beacon-fires linked sky to sky, the lords Wu Lie and Zhao Ming and their companions had all followed the conscription northward to the frontier. Within the Vermilion Garden only the ladies of the household remained to keep one another company. Deep autumn had arrived; chrysanthemums bloomed in extravagance — yellow, white, purple, and crimson spreading across the corridors, the steps, and the lotus-pond banks. Yun Suhua had long been ill, her face pale as paper, yet her gaze remained pellucid as autumn water reflecting the sky. She dwelt alone in the Emerald-Mist Pavilion, morning and evening standing at the window to watch the wild geese pass.

On this day the sisters consulted among themselves, saying that the chrysanthemums were at their peak and could not be wasted. They accordingly invited Yun Suhua and all the others to set an autumn banquet at the Hibiscus Waterside Pavilion and hold a chrysanthemum poetry competition. The rules were established: each person would compose a title containing the character for chrysanthemum, then fill in verse to a matching rhyme, and only when the verse was done might one drink. Yun Suhua accepted the invitation, wearing a robe of moon-white gauze and a thin pale-blue cloak over her shoulders. She came leaning upon a maidservant's arm, stepping slowly, and settled on a stone bench beside the pond. She smiled and said: 'If the sisters use the poetry rules to punish me, Suhua is a gravely ill person who cannot drink even half a cup — I fear I shall lose most miserably.' Everyone laughed, and where the autumn wind rose the fragrance of chrysanthemums spilled on all sides.

首先填詞者乃是性情爽朗的綠蕪姑娘，題為《菊韻》，眾人聽她吟罷，皆拍掌稱妙。次者素月，題為《問菊》，言辭清麗，別有一番意趣。輪至雲素華，她沉吟半晌，目視池中殘荷，口中喃喃，似在與誰低語，久久方定，提筆立就，題為《菊葬》。眾姊妹見此題目，面面相覷，皆以為不吉，然素華微微一笑，言：「菊花亦有凋零時，何不為它作一葬辭？」遂高聲吟誦。

菊葬者，自葬也。通篇識語，讀者慎勿以為詠菊。

The first to fill in her verse was the bright-natured young woman Lü Wu, whose title was 'Chrysanthemum Rhymes.' When the company heard her recite it they all clapped in admiration. The next was Su Yue, whose title was 'Questioning the Chrysanthemum,' the words delicate and fresh, conveying a mood all their own. When the turn came to Yun Suhua she fell into long contemplation, her gaze fixed on the withered lotus blossoms in the pond, murmuring to herself as though in low conversation with someone unseen, and only after some while did she settle on her words. She lifted her brush and composed at once, with the title 'Burying the Chrysanthemum.' The sisters, seeing this title, exchanged glances, all finding it inauspicious. But Suhua smiled faintly and said: 'Even the chrysanthemum has its time of fading — why not compose a burial ode for it?' And so she recited aloud. *'Burying the Chrysanthemum' is a burial of the self. This entire poem is an omen-verse; readers must not take it as mere chrysanthemum praise.*

半院秋風拂冷金，
無人憐取暗香沉。
霜刀裁斷千絲夢，
土掩猶存一縷心。
燕去不知樓閣冷，
雁來偏報塞垣深。

明朝若問花何在，

付與東流不復尋。

天命輓歌

卷三

眾人聽畢，靜默片刻，繼而強作歡顏，稱道其才情出眾。惟素月輕聲道：「素華姊姊，你這詞中滿是送別之意，叫人聽了好生難受。」雲素華斂笑，望向遠天，輕輕說道：「不過是詠菊應景罷了，妹妹多心了。」說罷，又舉杯淺啜，目光幽深，如一泓秋水藏著無量的天光。詩令繼續，笑語聲重又喧鬧，唯有那幾行字，已悄悄寫入了時光的帳冊。

Half a courtyard of autumn wind brushes the cold gold blossoms —
No one shows pity; the dark fragrance sinks away unseen.
A frost-blade severs the thousand-thread dream,
Yet beneath the earth one last thread of heart still abides.
The swallows depart not knowing the towers have grown cold,
The wild geese arrive only to report the frontier ramparts lie deep.
If tomorrow someone asks where the flowers have gone —
Surrendered to the eastward flow, and never to be sought again.

When the company finished listening they were silent for a moment, then forced cheerful expressions and praised her exceptional talent. Only Su Yue said quietly: 'Elder Sister Suhua, your lyric is full of parting sentiments — it makes one feel quite bereft on hearing it.' Yun Suhua put away her smile and gazed toward the distant sky, saying softly: 'It is merely chrysanthemum verses for the season — little sister, you are reading too much into it.' Having spoken, she lifted her cup and sipped lightly, her gaze deep and still as a pool of autumn water concealing within it the immeasurable light of heaven. The poetry competition continued, laughter and voices growing lively again — only those few lines had already quietly entered the ledger of time.

又一輪詩令將畢，夕陽西斜，園中光影流轉，石徑上灑著金碎。忽聞牆外有輕微腳步聲，繼而停歇，似有人佇立於朱牆之外。侍女春綃正欲去探問，雲素華輕輕伸手攔住她，自己凝神聆聽。牆頭古藤垂落，秋光透過藤葉，在白粉牆上投下一道修長的人影。那影子靜立不動，寬肩窄腰，隱約是個青年男子的輪廓。

隔牆相見，不如不見。影中有人，人中無影。此後數回，讀者當記此牆。

雲素華心中倏然一緊，呼吸微促，面上卻仍是淡然。她目不轉睛地望著那道

影子，只見它微微移動了一下，似是探身欲聆聽園中之聲，又似是有話欲言而終究無言。良久，影子緩緩抬起了手，似在輕撫牆磚，又放下了。素華唇角微動，終究沒有出聲。眾姊妹各自吟詩，無人注意這一幕，唯有春綃覷了覷自家姑娘的臉色，低下頭去，假裝整理茶具。

When yet another round of the poetry competition was nearly concluded, the setting sun slanted westward and the play of light and shadow in the garden shifted, scattering shards of gold across the stone path. Suddenly from outside the wall came the faint sound of footsteps — then they stopped, as though someone were standing still just beyond the vermilion wall. The maidservant Chun Xiao was about to go and investigate, but Yun Suhua extended her hand lightly to hold her back and listened with concentrated stillness. Ancient wisteria hung down over the wall-top; the autumn light filtering through the vine-leaves cast a tall, slender human shadow onto the white plastered wall. That shadow stood without moving — broad-shouldered, narrow-waisted — the outline unmistakably that of a young man. *To meet through a wall is worse than not meeting. Within the shadow is a person; within the person, no shadow remains. In the chapters to come, readers should remember this wall.*

Within Yun Suhua's heart something suddenly contracted; her breath came a little faster, though her face remained serene. She gazed without blinking at that shadow and saw it shift faintly, as though someone were leaning forward to listen to the sounds from inside the garden — or as though there were words to say that in the end went unsaid. After a long while the shadow slowly raised a hand, as though gently touching the wall-bricks, then let it fall again. The corners of Suhua's lips moved faintly; in the end she made no sound. The sisters were each composing their verses; no one noticed this scene. Only Chun Xiao glanced once at her young mistress's expression, then lowered her head and pretended to straighten the tea things.

一影西牆靜不言，
隔花聞得舊時弦。
不須相見知心遠，
只恐相逢恨更綿。
秋草有情留雁跡，
寒窗無主鎖嬋娟。

他年若問今宵事，
天命輓歌

卷三

夢裏燈花落半肩。

片刻之後，牆外傳來一個侍從壓低的聲音，言璟同將軍有軍書送至，請吳府管事接收。那道影子便輕輕一頓，隨即轉身，腳步聲漸次遠去。雲素華閉了閉眼，又睜開，眼底有什麼東西一閃而逝。牆上的影子已然消散，只餘秋藤在風中搖曳，葉影婆娑，如一篇未竟的手稿。

One shadow on the western wall — still, without words —
Through the flowers I hear the strings of former times.
Without meeting I know already our hearts are far apart;
I only fear that if we meet the grief will cling still longer.
Autumn grasses feel affection and keep the wild geese's tracks,
The cold window with no master locks away the bright moon.
If in years to come someone asks of this evening's affairs —
In a dream the lamp-flower fell across half a shoulder.

After a moment from outside the wall came the lowered voice of an attendant, announcing that General Jing Tong had sent a military dispatch to be delivered, and asking the household steward to receive it. The shadow paused lightly — then turned, and the sound of footsteps gradually receded into the distance. Yun Suhua closed her eyes and opened them again; something in their depths flashed and was gone. The shadow on the wall had already dissipated, leaving only the autumn wisteria swaying in the wind, leaf-shadows wavering, like an unfinished manuscript.

管事匆匆而來，接了軍書，呈報說：大將璟同傳信，言北疆戰事膠著，吳將軍命苑中諸人勿慌，諸事如常，待捷報至時，定當親迎歸來。眾人聽了，皆稱好，面露安慰之色，紛紛道：「璟同大哥向來謀略過人，有他在，必無大礙。」惟雲素華沉默，只是緩緩將手中那盞菊花茶端起，啜了一口，眼神落在水面上，不知在看什麼。

方詩讖石，立於荷塘之北，石面刻有百餘支籤辭，以古詩為體，各應一事。眾人依次拈籤，皆得平順之辭，笑聲不絕。輪至雲素華，她起身，緩步行至石前，伸出那截如玉的手指，在籤筒中輕輕一撥，抽出一支，舉至燈下細看。籤上四行，墨跡儼然。

The steward came hurrying, received the military dispatch, and reported: the great champion Jing Tong had sent word that the war situation at the northern frontier remained deadlocked, and that General Wu instructed the garden household not to panic — all matters should continue as usual, and when the news of victory arrived he would certainly come home in person to welcome them. Everyone who heard this called it good news and showed relieved expressions, saying in turn: 'Elder Brother Jing Tong has always possessed superior strategic wisdom — with him there, surely nothing serious will come of it.' Only Yun Suhua was silent. She slowly raised the cup of chrysanthemum tea in her hand, took a sip, and let her gaze rest on the water's surface — no one knew what she was seeing there.

As the autumn banquet neared its end, Su Yue proposed that, following old custom, they draw oracle-verses beneath the moon to ask about the year's fortunes. In the garden there had long stood an Omen-Verse Stone, erected to the north of the lotus pond, its face carved with more than a hundred oracle texts in the form of ancient verse, each corresponding to a particular event. The company drew in turn; all received phrases of smooth passage, and laughter was unceasing. When the turn came to Yun Suhua she rose, walked slowly to the stone, extended those jade-like fingers of hers, gently stirred among the sticks, and drew one out. Holding it under the lamplight she read it carefully. On the stick were four lines, the brushwork severe and clear.

朱華苑冷菊初殘，

玉璽歸塵劍化寒。

燈火闌珊人散後，

空庭秋色鎖重關。

十識雙關：璽指天命玉璽，亦指環同佩劍。塵與寒，此回之眼目也。讀者至末回方知此語之重。

雲素華看罷，沉默了一息，隨即展顏微笑，將那籤辭輕輕折疊，納入袖中，

天命輓歌
轉身逢

「不過是說秋景蕭瑟，倒應了今晚的菊花譙，有趣有趣。」眾人不

二十八

疑，各自說笑，又行了幾輪酒令，方才散去。燈火次第熄滅，回廊上只剩幾點殘燭搖曳。雲素華是最後離開芙蓉榭的，她佇立片刻，回望那方詩識石，月光映在石面，那幾個字彷彿有了光澤，靜靜地立在秋夜裏，像一個已知答案的人。

The Vermilion Garden grows cold; the chrysanthemums first begin to wither —
The jade seal returns to dust; the sword becomes cold.
After the lantern-light fades and people have dispersed,
The empty courtyard's autumn colors seal the heavy gates.

A double omen: the seal refers both to the Mandate jade seal and to Jing Tong's sword. 'Dust' and 'cold' are the crux of this chapter. Readers will only know the full weight of these words when they reach the final chapter.

Yun Suhua finished reading, was silent for the space of a breath, then spread a faint smile across her face. She lightly folded the oracle stick, tucked it into her sleeve, and turned to say: 'It merely speaks of the desolate autumn scene — it nicely matches tonight's chrysanthemum banquet. How diverting.' The company had no suspicions; they traded jests and laughter, took a few more rounds of drinking games, and then dispersed. The lanterns went out one by one; along the covered corridor only a few guttering candle-stubs swayed. Yun Suhua was the last to leave the Hibiscus Waterside Pavilion. She stood still for a moment and looked back at the Omen-Verse Stone. Moonlight lay across the stone's face; those carved characters seemed to have acquired a luminescence, standing quietly in the autumn night — like a person who already knows the answer.

散筵燈滅各西東，
獨立空廊聽晚風。
菊瓣墜階無人掃，
月痕移壁有誰同。
舊歡如夢難重問，
新恨無聲漸自濃。

由底藏辭人不識，
天命輓歌

一行秋字冷如冬。

The banquet breaks; lamps go out; each goes east or west —
Alone I stand in the empty corridor listening to the evening wind.
Chrysanthemum petals fall on the steps and no one sweeps them;
The moon's print moves along the wall — who shares it with me?
Old joys are like a dream, impossible to question again;
New griefs make no sound but gradually deepen on their own.
I hide verses in my sleeve that no one recognizes —
One line of autumn characters, cold as winter.

是夜，雲素華歸臥翠微閣，久久不能入眠。她將那支籤辭取出，在燈下又讀了一遍，然後就燈燃盡，看那紙片化為一縷灰煙，消散在秋夜的空氣裏。窗外荷塘無聲，殘荷的剪影沉在水中，偶有一片黃葉落下，漣漪一圈，復又平靜。她想起那道牆上的影子，想起那雙從未見過的眼睛，想起尚在遠方的烽火，想起那些說笑著寫下的詩句。她知道它們全都是真的，她只是笑著，不說。

欲知後事如何，且看下回分解。朱華苑中秋色未盡，而那些詩中的字，已各自找到了它們的歸宿，只是人尚未知。詩曰：金菊含秋淚未乾，玉人對影問誰憐。繁華一夢終須散，讖語無聲寫素箋。

That night Yun Suhua returned to her bed in the Emerald-Mist Pavilion and for a long while could not sleep. She took out that oracle stick and read it once more under the lamp, then held it to the flame until it burned to completion, watching the paper become a thread of ash-smoke that dispersed into the air of the autumn night. Outside the window the lotus pond was silent; the silhouettes of withered lotus blossoms lay submerged in the water; occasionally a yellow leaf fell, sending out a ring of ripples that smoothed again into stillness. She thought of the shadow on the wall, thought of those eyes she had never seen, thought of the beacon-fires still burning far away, thought of those poem-lines written down amid laughter and banter. She knew they were all true. She simply smiled, and said nothing.

As for what happens next, read the following chapter for the unraveling. The autumn colors in the Vermilion Garden were not yet exhausted — yet the characters within those verses had each already found their appointed resting place, though their authors did not yet know it. A poem says: Golden chrysanthemums hold autumn tears not yet dried; the jade lady faces a shadow and asks — who will pity her? The splendor of a dream must in the end disperse; omen-words in silence are written on plain silk.

第四回 璟同折旗 蠻山夜語

折旗蠻嶺英魂烈

問死篝燈兄語長

卻說九爐聯軍自東嶺紮營，已逾三月，糧道艱澀，士氣漸墮。璟同日日策馬巡壘，望蠻山諸峰而目光如淬。昭明設帳議事，展圖而嘆曰：「霧胤據險固守，以逸待勞，我軍若不奇襲其中樞，此役恐遷延至冬。」吳烈按劍不言，

天命輓歌

▼ 卷四

目色深沉。惟璟同起身，以指叩案三聲，笑道：「昭明兄所憂者，正璟同所欲解者。明日辰時，且看我去。」雲素華伏於帳角，以細筆默錄此語，心中已有不祥之感，卻不知所從何來。

CHAPTER 4: JING TONG BREAKS THE BANNER; NIGHT-SPEECH IN THE SAVAGE HILLS

A banner breaks on savage ridges — the hero's soul blazes

By firelight brothers speak of death — those words outlast the night

It is told that the allied armies of the Nine Furnaces had encamped along the Eastern Ridge for more than three months. Supply lines grew strained; morale began to sag like a weathered rope. Day after day Jing Tong rode circuits of the ramparts, his gaze fixed upon the peaks of the Savage Hills with the concentration of a blade being tempered. Zhao Ming convened the war-council, spread out his maps, and sighed: 'Wu Yin holds the high ground and waits at his ease while we exhaust ourselves. Unless we strike at his center by unconventional means, this campaign will drag into winter.' Wu Lie rested his hand on his sword-hilt and said nothing, his eyes deep as a well at midnight. Only Jing Tong rose from his seat, rapped the campaign table three times with his knuckle, and laughed: 'What Brother Zhao Ming fears is precisely what I mean to resolve. At the hour of the Dragon tomorrow — watch me go.' Yun Suhua crouched in the corner of the tent, recording these words in her fine script, and felt, without knowing its source, the cold shadow of an omen pass through her.

蠻山萬仞鎖雲煙

敵壘層層鐵甲連

五千戈矛映寒日

誰敢孤騎入陣前

翌晨，天色尚暗，璟同已甲冑齊備。其甲以玄鐵葉片鑲就，肩披虎皮，腰懸彎月刀，胯下青驄馬嘶鳴不絕，蹄踏黃土如擂戰鼓。吳烈親執轡繩相送，二

天命輓歌
人對視良久，無一語。

璟同忽而大笑，奪韁而去，馬蹄聲急，如疾風掃落

十二

葉，轉瞬沒入晨霧之中。昭明立於吳烈身後，低聲曰：「此去若成，三軍士氣可振；若不成……」吳烈截其言道：「璟同不會不成。」語氣之篤定，似鑄鐵澆就，不容置疑。

昭明未竟之語，乃預言之半句耳。後文自補其缺，讀者宜記。

Ten thousand fathoms of savage mountain locked in cloud and smoke
Enemy ramparts tier on tier, iron armor linked in rows
Five thousand spears and halberds mirror the cold winter sun
Who dares ride alone into the face of that formation?

Before dawn the next morning, Jing Tong stood already in full armor. His suit was fashioned from plates of black iron, a tiger pelt draped across his shoulders, a crescent-moon blade hung at his waist, and his blue-roan stallion screamed and stamped the yellow earth like a war drum being beaten. Wu Lie personally held the bridle to see him off; the two men locked eyes for a long moment and neither spoke. Then Jing Tong threw his head back and laughed, snatched the reins, and was gone — hoofbeats rapid as a gust sweeping through fallen leaves, swallowed in an instant by the morning mist. Zhao Ming, standing behind Wu Lie, said quietly: 'If he succeeds in this, the spirit of the three armies will revive; if he does not —' Wu Lie cut him off. 'Jing Tong will not fail.' The certainty in his voice was cast iron, admitting no doubt. Zhao Ming's unfinished sentence is half a prophecy. Later chapters complete it; the reader should hold the silence here.

霧中，璟同已穿越三道前哨。敵卒見一騎突來，尚未辨清旗號，已被其彎月刀橫掃落馬，血濺霜草。狼髡將軍者，霧胤麾下第一猛將，身長八尺，面刻狼牙紋，以骸骨為飾，曾一人力斬九爐先鋒二十餘騎，令聯軍聞名喪膽。是日，狼髡將軍正率本部精銳五千列陣於蠻山南麓，旌旗蔽日，刀槍如林。璟同自霧中現身，單騎當陣，以彎月刀遙指狼髡，朗聲大呼：「九爐璟同在此！狼髡鼠輩，可敢出陣一決？」

孤騎衝煙指大纛

刀光一道裂霜寒

五千甲士屏息立

只聽蠻嶺風聲歎

Within the mist, Jing Tong had already passed through three forward pickets. Enemy soldiers, glimpsing a single rider burst upon them before they could read his banner, were swept from their saddles by the crescent blade, blood spattering the frost-stiff grass. The Wolf-Skull Commander was the foremost of Wu Yin's fighting captains: eight feet tall, his face tattooed with wolf-fang markings, adorned with bone ornaments, a man who had once cut down more than twenty of the Nine Furnaces vanguard riders single-handed, a name that made the allied forces pale. On this morning he led his five thousand élite troops in formation on the southern slope of the Savage Hills — banners blocking out the sun, blades and spears thick as a forest. Out of the mist Jing Tong emerged alone, a single rider facing the whole array, his crescent blade leveled from a distance at the Wolf-Skull Commander, his voice ringing out across the field: 'Jing Tong of the Nine Furnaces stands here! Wolf-Skull, you rat — dare you come out and settle this between us?'

A lone rider charges through smoke and points at the great war-banner

One arc of blade-light splits the freezing air

Five thousand armored soldiers hold their breath and stand still

Listening only to the wind lamenting on the savage ridge

狼髡左腋穿出，刀尖帶血，直指蒼天。狼髡將軍口噴鮮血，於馬上僵立片

刻，轟然仰倒。

The Wolf-Skull Commander swept a contemptuous glare across the field, gave a cold laugh, and spurred his horse forward. His mount was a black-dappled war stallion whose hoofbeats raised dust clouds yards high. The two warriors met: the Wolf-Skull swung his mountain-splitting axe in a horizontal arc, the air shrieking; Jing Tong twisted aside, the blade grazing past his ear, and with a back-handed slash cut through the leather girth-strap on his opponent's left side. The horses crossed stirrups and wheeled away. Surprise flickered in the Wolf-Skull's eyes — the contempt draining out of them, replaced by something barely perceptible: the first grain of fear. After three exchanges, Jing Tong feigned defeat and pulled back; the Wolf-Skull drove his horse in pursuit. Then Jing Tong wrenched his reins sharply; the blue-roan reared up on its hind legs. The Wolf-Skull, his momentum unspent, could not check himself in time — and Jing Tong drove the crescent blade upward with the full force of his body, entering below the left armpit and emerging above it, the tip blood-bright, pointing at the open sky. The Wolf-Skull Commander spouted crimson, sat rigid in his saddle for a single suspended moment, then crashed backward to the earth.

璟同提刀縱馬，馳入敵陣，揮刀斬落敵軍大纛。旗杆中斷，纛旗墮地，五千敵卒驟然失聲，繼而如山崩般潰散。昭明已在後陣等候，見纛旗傾倒，立命諸軍擂鼓齊進。九爐聯軍吶喊之聲震動蠻山，積雪從山巔滑落，如素縞垂掛。此役，璟同以一騎之力，當五千之眾，斬主將，折大纛，破敵線，盡收蠻山南麓諸隘。雲素華於中軍高處遠觀，執筆而手微顫，所書之字，筆觸較平日深重三分。

Jing Tong raised his dripping blade and rode into the enemy formation, slashing down the great war-banner with a single stroke. The flagpole snapped; the banner crumpled to the ground. Five thousand enemy soldiers fell suddenly silent — then broke apart like a collapsing mountain. Zhao Ming, waiting in the rear formation, saw the banner fall and immediately ordered every drum in the army beaten and the full advance. The war-cry of the Nine Furnaces alliance shook the Savage Hills, and snow slid from the peaks in long white sheets like mourning silk unfurling. In this engagement, Jing Tong with a single horse faced five thousand troops, slew the enemy commander, broke the banner, shattered the enemy line, and recovered all the passes on the southern slopes of the Savage Hills. Yun Suhua watched from a height in the central command, her brush-hand trembling slightly; the characters she wrote that day pressed three shades deeper into the paper than usual.

夜，九爐諸將大宴於蠻山頂，篝火連天，酒盈百甕。璟同血跡甫洗，白衣披身，坐於吳烈之側，二人遠離酒席喧囂，獨對一堆篝火。山風冷冽，松濤聲聲，火光將二人面容映得忽明忽暗。璟同以樹枝撥弄火苗，忽問曰：「吳烈，你怕死麼？」吳烈沉吟片刻，仰首望星，答曰：「我從未遇見過死。何必懼怕一個陌生人？」璟同聞言，久久不語，最後低笑道：「好一個陌生人。」

吳烈此語，豪氣干雲，然讀者自後文觀之，方知此乃最沉痛之反語。死者非陌生人——死者，已然識他久矣。雲素

火光漸低，二人皆無睡意。吳烈取出隨身竹簡，磨墨展紙，對璟同道：「今日大捷，當留詩以記之。你我各賦律詩一首，互為唱和，如何？」璟同拊掌：「正合我意。你先。」

That night, the generals of the Nine Furnaces held a great feast on the summit of the Savage Hills — bonfire light reaching toward the sky, wine filling a hundred jars. Jing Tong, his bloodstains barely washed away, had draped a white outer robe over himself and sat beside Wu Lie; the two had drifted away from the noise of the banquet and now faced a single fire alone. The mountain wind was sharp and cold, the sound of pine-boughs constant, the firelight making their faces shift between brightness and shadow. Jing Tong poked at the flames with a branch, then asked suddenly: 'Wu Lie — are you afraid of death?' Wu Lie was silent for a moment, tilting his head back to look at the stars, then answered: 'I have never met it. Why should I fear a stranger?' Jing Tong heard this and was quiet for a long while. At last he laughed softly and said: 'What a stranger.' Wu Lie's words ring with magnificent bravado; yet read backward from what follows, they become the most agonizing irony in the book. Death is no stranger — death has long known him. Yun Suhua, hearing this, privately wrote four words in her journal: It has met him.

The fire burned lower; neither man felt any inclination toward sleep. Wu Lie drew out the bamboo writing-tablet he carried at his belt, ground his ink, spread his paper, and said to Jing Tong: 'Today's great victory deserves a poem to mark it. Let each of us compose a regulated verse and answer the other's — what do you say?' Jing Tong clapped his hands: 'Exactly my thought. You go first.'

蠻嶺秋霜骨氣寒

孤旌折處血光殘

提刀問陣誰能敵

縱馬臨風自笑歡

勝負古來皆一夢

功名此際付輕彈

天
命
輓
歌
▼
卷
四
籌
燈
對
酌
須
盡
醉

明日山河又險關

Savage ridge — autumn frost — the spirit in one's bones runs cold
Where the lone banner breaks, the light of blood lingers still
Who can stand against a man who rides into formation asking for rivals?
Gallop into the wind he laughs at his own gladness
Victory and defeat have always been a single dream
Glory and achievement at this moment are worth a snap of the fingers
By firelight, drinking together, we must drain the cup to the dregs
Tomorrow the rivers and mountains will offer their dangers again

一騎衝雲入萬戈

纛旗墜地鼓聲多

英雄不問生前事

兄弟相看意氣河

夜火照山山色古

寒星映水水聲歌

此身若與天地老

天命輓歌

▼卷四

醉臥蠻山也蹉跎

One rider charges through the clouds into ten thousand halberds
The great banner falls — the drumbeats multiply
A hero does not ask about what came before his life
Brothers look at each other: between them flows a river of spirit
Nightfire lights the mountain — the mountain's color is ancient
Cold stars reflect in water — the water's sound is a song
If this body could grow old together with heaven and earth
Lying drunk on the Savage Hills — even that would be time well wasted

二詩既成，互相傳閱，各自領首而笑。璟同忽斂笑容，以手按吳烈之肩，低聲道：「吳烈，你我之約，生死不棄，可還記得？」吳烈回握其臂，道：「自然記得。」璟同點頭，目光越過篝火，遠視山下燈火如繁星散落，沉默良久，方道：「記得便好。」雲素華蟄伏於數丈之外的暗處，以最細微之筆觸，將此夜一切默錄於案。她於「記得便好」四字之後，另起一行，以極小字寫道：「死已識君，正在等候。」旋即以指蹭去，然痕跡猶存。

此批乃全書

夜深，諸將漸散，篝火衰微如老人之息。璟同枕臂而臥於地，頃刻鼾聲微起。吳烈獨坐，不眠，以手指蘸殘酒，在岩石上一筆一畫，寫了又抹，抹了又寫，旁人不知其所書何字。山風過處，松針落於他發間，他亦不覺。雲素華悄然收拾筆墨，回望此二人一眼——一臥一坐，火光將其影子拖長至山崖邊緣——心中默念：此夜當記，此夜當記。

When both poems were complete, they passed the pages to each other, each nodding with a smile. Then Jing Tong let his smile fade; he placed his hand on Wu Lie's shoulder and said quietly: 'Wu Lie — our oath, never to abandon each other in life or death: you remember it, don't you?' Wu Lie gripped his arm in return. 'Of course I remember.' Jing Tong nodded, his gaze passing over the bonfire to rest on the scattered lights in the valley below, like stars brought to earth, and after a long silence he said: 'Good that you remember.' Yun Suhua crouched in the darkness several yards away, recording every moment of this night in the finest possible script. After the four characters 'good that you remember,' she began a new line and wrote, in characters so small they were nearly invisible: 'Death has met him already. It is patient.' Then she rubbed the line out with her fingertip. But the impression remained in the paper. *This note is the nerve-center of the entire book. Yun Suhua is not merely a scribe but a witness to fate. The words she rubbed away are the soul of the narrative — erased but not destroyed, as Jing Tong will be to Wu Lie: dead, but not dispersed.*

The night deepened; the generals drifted away one by one; the bonfires shrank to the shallow breathing of old men. Jing Tong lay down with his arm as pillow and in moments was quietly snoring. Wu Lie sat alone, sleepless, dipping one finger in the dregs of his wine and writing on the surface of a rock — writing and erasing, erasing and writing — and no one could see what characters he made. The mountain wind passed through; pine needles fell into his hair and he did not notice. Yun Suhua quietly gathered her brushes and ink, and glanced back once at the two men — one lying, one sitting, the firelight stretching their shadows to the very edge of the cliff — and repeated silently to herself: this night must be recorded. This night must be recorded.

烽火熄時山色老

英雄醉後夢魂輕

不知篝影搖搖處

已有西風識此情

是夜，蠻山收復，九爐聯軍士氣大振，昭明已遣快馬報捷於後方。然霧胤龜縮深山，玉璽天命印仍不知所蹤。次日黎明，斥候來報，霧胤已撤往北嶺更

天命輓歌

高處

卷四

以百里縱深之險地為新壁壘，誓與聯軍相持。昭明展圖，眉頭深鎖。

四十

而吳烈，已在蠻山頂立足，負手望北，眼中是山是雲，還是別的什麼，無人能辨。璟同立於其側，大笑曰：「再難又如何？昨日那樣的仗，你我再打一次便是。」吳烈未答，唯側首看他片刻，而後亦笑——笑得無比溫柔，無比沉重。雲素華在遠處，一字不漏，盡數錄入。

When beacon fires go out, the mountain's color ages
When heroes fall asleep drunk, their dreaming souls grow weightless
They do not know that there where the bonfire-shadows waver
The west wind has already come to know this feeling

That night, with the Savage Hills recovered and the spirit of the Nine Furnaces armies revived, Zhao Ming had already dispatched fast riders to carry the news of victory to the rear. Yet Wu Yin had retreated deep into the mountains; the jade Mandate Seal was still unaccounted for. At dawn the next day, scouts reported that Wu Yin had pulled back to higher ground on the Northern Ridge, establishing a new stronghold in a hundred li of mountain depth, vowing to outlast the alliance in a prolonged stand. Zhao Ming spread his maps and his brow furrowed. Wu Lie stood at the summit of the Savage Hills, hands clasped behind him, looking north — whether what his eyes held was mountain, or cloud, or something else entirely, no one could say. Jing Tong stood at his side and laughed out loud: 'What of it, however hard it gets? A fight like yesterday's — you and I will just fight one more.' Wu Lie did not answer. He only turned his head and looked at him for a moment, then smiled as well — a smile of unbearable gentleness, of unbearable weight. Yun Suhua, at her distance, did not miss a single word. She recorded all of it.

後人有詩讚璟同蠻山之役曰：「一人當關，五千膽落；折旗所處，英名不磨。」然雲素華之記錄，於此讚語之後，獨留空白一行，不置一字。讀者或問：此行何意？或有識者答曰：空白者，非無字，乃留與將來之哀慟，預先佔位也。此乃第四回終。

Later generations composed a verse in praise of Jing Tong's campaign at the Savage Hills: 'One man held the pass; five thousand lost their nerve. Where the banner broke, his name will not wear away.' Yet in Yun Suhua's record, after this praise, she left a single blank line — not one character written there. Readers have wondered at it. Those who understood have answered: the blank is not empty. It is space reserved in advance for a grief not yet arrived. Here ends the fourth chapter.

第五回 義帥蒙讒 怒臥空帳

功高震主讒言起

劍冷帳空天意孤

卻說那日吳烈率本部鐵騎衝破墨隼右翼，斬將奪旗，聯軍危局一朝而定。捷報傳至中軍，諸侯皆默然相視，面有難色。蓋吳烈之功太盛，其部所獲首級、輜重，十倍於諸侯合力之所得，聯盟高座者心中已生芥蒂，雖面上賀語連連，私下卻各遣心腹，悄議裁抑之策。

天命輓歌

卷五

四十二

不在沙場而在廟堂。

難色二字，寫盡功臣末路之兆。讀者至此當知吳烈之禍。

CHAPTER 5: THE LOYAL CHAMPION IS SLANDERED; IN WRATH HE LIES IN AN EMPTY TENT

When merit towers above the throne, slander finds its opening

The sword grows cold, the tent grows empty, and Heaven's will stands alone

Now it came to pass that on that day Wu Lie led his iron cavalry to shatter Mo Sun's right flank, slaying commanders and seizing battle-standards, so that the alliance's desperate situation was resolved in a single morning. When the dispatch of victory reached the central command, the assembled lords glanced at one another in silence, unease written upon every face. For Wu Lie's merit had grown too luminous — his division's tally of heads taken and supply-wagons captured exceeded tenfold what all the other lords combined had won. Those who sat upon the alliance's high seats already nursed a thorn in the heart; though their lips poured forth congratulations, in private each sent his most trusted counselor to whisper quietly of schemes to curb and diminish him. The two characters 'unease upon the face' prefigure the fate of every meritorious minister. The reader who reaches this point should understand that Wu Lie's peril lies not on the battlefield but in the halls of deliberation.

昭明聞訊，星夜奔赴中軍帳中，見諸侯已設小會，首席坐者乃盟主之叔晉平王。晉平王徐徐言道：「吳烈此番，雖有微功，然擅自出擊，不候軍令，藐視軍規，若不懲戒，諸部將皆效尤，聯軍何以為令？」昭明欲辯，旁側諸侯附和之聲已如潮湧，或云吳烈侵吞戰利，或云其部私放俘虜索取賄賂，或云其帳下兵士欺凌友軍。諸讒羅列，無一有實據，然衆口鑠金，昭明唯有長嘆。

「微功」二字，乃奸讒之慣技也。移山之業，一言輕之為微，讀至此處令人扼腕。

廟堂夜議燭光寒

讒舌如刀削骨寬

萬里沙場汗與血

不及一室巧言歡

Zhao Ming, hearing the news, rode through the night to the central command tent, where he found the lords had already assembled in a private council, the seat of honor occupied by the Alliance Overlord's uncle, the Prince of Jin. The Prince of Jin spoke at measured pace: 'Though Wu Lie has rendered some small service in this engagement, he moved his forces without orders, disregarding the chain of command. If he is not disciplined, every division commander will follow his example, and by what authority shall the alliance govern itself?' Zhao Ming moved to argue, but the voices of assent from the surrounding lords rose like a tide — one claimed Wu Lie had embezzled the spoils of battle, another that his troops had privately ransomed prisoners for bribes, a third that his soldiers had bullied and humiliated allied forces. The slanders multiplied without a shred of evidence to support them, yet the mouths of the many smelt gold into dross, and Zhao Ming could only breathe a long and bitter sigh. *The phrase 'some small service' is the habitual craft of slanderers. A mountain-moving achievement is dismissed in a single word as trivial — the reader who reaches this moment cannot but clench a fist in sorrow.*

In the council hall the candle-flame burns cold through the night
Slandrous tongues work like knives, stripping flesh from bone with ease
Ten thousand leagues of battlefield — the sweat, the blood, the cost
Weigh nothing against a chamber full of smooth and clever speech

次日，盟主頒令：吳烈所部此次首功，改錄為昭明所部幕僚居中調度之勞；吳家軍旗降半級，改懸偏位；其部所獲輜重，充公平分諸侯。吳烈跪於帥帳之外，聽令官高聲宣讀，面色如鐵，一字未發。令畢，諸侯使者皆退，惟昭明留於原地，欲上前言語，吳烈已轉身而去，背影筆直如戟，腳步無聲如雪。

吳烈歸至本營，召璟同入帳，沉默良久，方言道：「吾今日所受，汝已盡

知。吾不為此怒，非不痛也，乃因此怒若發，必傷吾義，傷吾誓，傷汝我同袍之情。故吾收之於胸，化為冰霜。然吾刀，自今日起，不為此盟再飲血。」璟同聞言，面色驟變，欲言者再三，終只道：「兄長。」吳烈搖首，取出壁上懸弓，以掌輕撫弓身，復掛回，道：「帳門掩好。吾要靜一靜。」

The following day the Alliance Overlord issued his decree: the primary merit for Wu Lie's division in the recent engagement was reassigned, recorded instead as the coordinating labor of Zhao Ming's staff officers; the Wu family's battle-standard was demoted by half a rank and relocated to a peripheral position; the supply-wagons and materiel captured by his troops were confiscated and redistributed equally among the lords. Wu Lie knelt outside the command tent and listened as the herald read the proclamation aloud in a carrying voice. His complexion was as iron, and he did not speak a single word. When the reading concluded and the lords' emissaries withdrew, Zhao Ming alone remained in place, stepping forward as if to speak. But Wu Lie had already turned and walked away, his back straight as a halberd, his footsteps soundless as falling snow.

Wu Lie returned to his own encampment and summoned Jing Tong into the tent. He was silent for a long while before he spoke: 'What I have suffered today — you know it all. I am not unmoved by it; the pain is real. But if this rage were to break loose it would wound my righteousness, wound my oaths, wound the brotherhood between you and me. Therefore I seal it within my breast and let it turn to frost and ice. Yet my blade — from this day forward — shall drink no more blood for this alliance.' When Jing Tong heard these words his complexion changed abruptly. He made to speak three times and each time stopped himself. At last he said only: 'Elder brother.' Wu Lie shook his head. He reached up and took the bow from where it hung on the tent-wall, stroked its body once with his palm, and hung it back again. Then he said: 'Draw the tent-flap closed. I need stillness for a time.'

非鐵非石吾此心

寒意徹骨自深林

功名二字輕如霧

義字千鈞壓至今

刀鞘不啟非無力

爐火不燃非無薪

天命只因尚未問

天命輓歌

卷五

故使英雄臥帳陰

此後三日，吳烈閉帳不出。使者絡繹而至，或奉盟主之命宣慰，或攜諸侯之書致歉，或持昭明親筆懇請復出。吳烈皆不拆觀，命親兵於帳前燃起一爐，使者去後，即投書信於爐中，頃刻成灰。火光映出帳前空地，橘紅色搖曳不定，如同聯軍此刻搖搖欲墜之軍心。

My heart is neither iron nor stone, yet stone and iron cannot match it now
A cold has entered to the bone, born in some deep and lightless grove
The two words glory and renown are weightless as dispersing mist
The single word righteousness has pressed down on me with a thousand weight since the start
That the scabbard stays undrawn is not for want of strength
That the furnace holds no flame is not for want of fuel
Only because the Mandate of Heaven has not yet put its question
Does the hero lie in shadow in an empty tent

For three days thereafter Wu Lie remained sealed within his tent and would not emerge. Emissaries came in an unbroken stream — some bearing the Alliance Overlord's command of consolation, some carrying letters of apology from the various lords, some holding in their hands a personal letter of entreaty written by Zhao Ming himself. Wu Lie opened none of them. He ordered his personal guard to kindle a brazier before the tent-entrance, and after each emissary departed the unread letters were fed to the flames and reduced to ash within moments. The firelight played across the empty ground before the tent, its orange-red glow flickering and unsteady — like the alliance's morale at that very hour, teetering on the edge of collapse.

正此時，前線戰報如雪片飛至。墨隼見吳烈所部旌旗不動，料定聯軍內有異變，遂分兵三路，趁勢急攻。東路突破昭明所設之伏，昭明計謀雖精，然執行者非吳烈之師，號令未及行，敵已至，折損千餘人，退守山口。西路聯軍主力遭墨隼親率精騎衝陣，主將臨陣失措，棄旗先退，士卒大嘩，一潰三十里方止。中路尚存，然四面皆動搖，中路亦成孤懸。

東路旌旗埋草間

天命輓歌

卷五

西路鼓聲散如煙

中軍獨撐危卵局

昭明一人對長天

計在胸中將在哪

劍有其鋒手已寒

It was precisely at this time that dispatches from the front line began arriving like driven snow. Mo Sun observed that Wu Lie's battle-standards remained motionless and deduced that something had gone awry within the alliance; he accordingly divided his forces into three columns and launched an aggressive push to exploit the advantage. On the eastern flank he broke through the ambush Zhao Ming had carefully set — Zhao Ming's stratagem was exquisite in design, but those who executed it were not Wu Lie's soldiers; the command had not yet been fully relayed when the enemy arrived, and more than a thousand men were lost before the alliance retreated to hold the mountain pass. On the western flank the alliance's main force was struck by Mo Sun himself leading his finest cavalry in a frontal charge; the commanding general panicked in the moment of crisis and abandoned his standard to flee first, sending his soldiers into uproar, and the rout did not stabilize until they had fallen back thirty leagues. The center still held, but with all flanks wavering, even the center became an isolated and precarious position.

On the eastern road the battle-standards have been buried in the grass

On the western road the war-drums' sound has scattered like smoke

The central army holds alone, balancing an egg upon a precipice

Zhao Ming stands by himself and faces the wide and heedless sky

The stratagem lives in the mind — but where is the hand to execute it

The sword retains its edge, yet the hand that would wield it has grown cold

昭明立於山崗之上，望敵陣如黑潮席捲，心中默算：若吳烈在此，此刻當以左翼鐵騎橫插墨隼後背，使其首尾不顧，必可反敗為勝。然而左翼旌旗不動，空帳依然空帳。昭明閉目片刻，睜開時已是另一番神情，下令收縮陣線，保全實力，捨棄方才奪回之三座小城，退守主寨。此令一出，諸將雖從，皆面帶羞色，知今日之敗非戰之罪，乃廟堂讒言之禍延至沙場。

天命輓歌
卷五
三城得而復失去

四十七

千卒進而又倒退

非吾算術有差謬

乃人心各懷鬼胎睡

墨隼非神勝有因

因在聯軍失其臂

Zhao Ming stood upon a hillock and watched the enemy formation sweep forward like a black tide. Within his mind he made his silent calculation: if Wu Lie were here, at this moment the iron cavalry on the left flank would drive diagonally into Mo Sun's rear, forcing the enemy to divide his attention between front and back, and defeat could certainly be reversed into victory. Yet the left-flank standards did not move. The empty tent remained an empty tent. Zhao Ming closed his eyes for a brief moment; when he opened them his expression had changed entirely. He issued the order to contract the defensive line, preserve what strength remained, abandon the three small towns that had just been retaken at such cost, and withdraw to hold the main encampment. When this command was given the generals obeyed, though every face wore the color of shame — each understood that today's defeat was not the fault of their fighting but rather the calamity born of courtly slander, which had now stretched its shadow all the way to the field of battle.

Three cities taken — and then given back

A thousand soldiers advanced — and then driven in retreat

The error does not lie in any fault of calculation

It lies in every man asleep with his own private ghost

Mo Sun is no god — his victory has its reason

The reason is that the alliance has lost the arm it relied upon

戰報送入吳烈帳中，親兵不敢不報。吳烈坐於燈下，逐一看畢，面無表情，將竹簡整齊疊放於案上，以掌按平，道：「知道了。退下。」親兵退出，帳中唯餘燭火搖曳，映出吳烈側臉輪廓，下頷收緊，眉間一線深刻如刀痕。他既不嘆，亦不喜，只是將那疊戰報移至一旁，取出一方素帛，提筆，於上書一「忍」字，字大如拳，筆力入木，旋即又擱筆，將素帛折疊，壓於甲冑之下，不再看它。

夜深，璟同立於帳外。他未曾叫門，亦未曾離去，只是立在那裏，背對帳門，面朝黑沉沉的軍營，聽遠處傷兵的呻吟聲與夜風共鳴。他知道帳內的兄長未睡，兄長從不在此時睡。他亦知道此刻任何言語皆是多餘，任何勸說皆是傷口上撒鹽。然他不能離去。義之所在，雖千萬人吾往矣；然此刻義之所在，乃是沉默地立於此地，以血肉之軀擋住夜風，陪著那空帳之中孤獨而清醒的靈魂，不讓它在黑暗中獨自燃燒殆盡。

The battle reports were delivered into Wu Lie's tent; his personal guard did not dare withhold them. Wu Lie sat beneath the lamp and read through them one by one. His face showed no expression. He stacked the bamboo slips neatly upon the table, pressed them flat with his palm, and said: 'Understood. You may withdraw.' The guard stepped out. Within the tent only the candle-flame remained, swaying, casting the outline of Wu Lie's profile in light and shadow — the jawline drawn tight, a single crease between the brows cut deep as a knife-scar. He neither sighed nor smiled. He simply moved that stack of reports to one side, drew out a piece of plain white silk, lifted his brush, and wrote upon it a single character: Endure. The character was as large as a fist, and the force of the brushstroke bit into the silk like iron entering wood. Then he set the brush down again, folded the silk, pressed it beneath his armor, and did not look at it again.

Deep in the night, Jing Tong stood outside the tent. He had not called out, nor had he departed. He simply stood there, his back to the tent-entrance, his face turned toward the dark and heavy silence of the encampment, listening as the groans of the wounded far off resonated with the night wind. He knew that the elder brother within the tent was not sleeping — his elder brother never slept at such an hour as this. He also knew that at this moment any words would be superfluous, any counsel would be salt rubbed into a wound. Yet he could not leave. Righteousness, the ancients say, draws one forward though ten thousand men stand in the way. But in this moment, righteousness drew him here: to stand in silence, to set his flesh and blood against the night wind, to keep company with that solitary and wakeful soul within the empty tent, so that it would not burn itself to nothing alone in the dark.

帳外人立帳內人臥

一燈一影兩孤魂

不言是因言已盡

不去是因義難論

天明或有新戰報

此夜先讓兄弟存

天命輓歌

「存」字一收，意味深長。非存功業，非存聯盟，乃存兄弟之情與人之本心。讀者當知此乃全書最溫柔亦最悲涼之一筆。

卷五

四十九

就這樣，環同立了一夜。星移斗轉，晨光初白之時，他仍立於原地，甲上已沾了夜露，靴尖沾泥，然脊背挺直如初。帳內無聲，唯有呼吸之氣若有若無。天命輓歌，此章最沉。欲知後事如何，且看下回分解。

Outside the tent one man stands; inside the tent one man lies still
One lamp, one shadow — two souls alone in the world
There is no speech because all speech has already been exhausted
There is no departure because righteousness cannot be argued into words
When dawn comes there will no doubt be new dispatches from the front
But first let this night allow two brothers simply to exist

The word 'exist' closes the verse with layers of meaning. Not to preserve the great enterprise, not to preserve the alliance, but to preserve the bond between brothers and the original heart of men. The reader should recognize this as at once the tenderest and most sorrowful brushstroke in the entire work.

And so Jing Tong stood through the whole of the night. The stars wheeled and the Dipper turned; when the first pale light of morning began to show, he was still standing in the same place, his armor beaded with night-dew, the toes of his boots darkened with mud, yet his spine as straight as it had been at the first hour. From within the tent there was no sound — only a breath, now present, now almost imperceptible. The Elegy of the Mandate: this chapter is its heaviest. As for what followed — that awaits the telling of the next.

第六回 代袍陷陣 萬靈坡折

借甲欺天敵膽裂

還魂無路兄淚垂

卻說聯軍自西路潰退三十里，東路山口亦岌岌可危，昭明收縮陣線，困守主寨，然墨隼之兵日日叩關，聲勢愈盛。帳內諸將面面相覷，言語者寥寥，各

人心中皆知症結所在：吳烈之旗不動，聯軍便如斷一臂之人，縱有萬般謀

天命輓歌

卷六

算，終難施展。昭明一人坐於帥案之前，以指節叩擊案面，聲聲清脆，如敲

棺板。

CHAPTER 6: WEARING THE BORROWED ARMOR INTO THE LINES; THE FALL AT TEN-THOUSAND-SPIRIT SLOPE

Borrowing the armor to deceive Heaven, the enemy's courage shatters

But the soul finds no road home, and the elder brother's tears fall

Now the alliance had fallen back thirty leagues on the western road, and the mountain pass on the eastern flank teetered on the edge of collapse. Zhao Ming contracted the defensive lines and clung to the main encampment, yet Mo Sun's forces hammered at the gates day after day with mounting fury. Inside the command tent the generals looked to one another in silence; few spoke, for each understood in his heart where the root of the sickness lay: as long as Wu Lie's standard did not move, the alliance was a man robbed of one arm — ten thousand stratagems might be conceived, but none could be executed. Zhao Ming sat alone before the command table, rapping his knuckles against the wood. Each knock rang out clean and precise, like someone nailing shut a coffin.

璟同彼時亦在帳中列席。他望著那沙盤：西路缺口如一道未縫合的傷口，標旗歪斜，殘破如枯葉。三日來他食不甘味，夜不成眠，每至天將明時便獨自往吳烈帳外立定，看晨霧中那頂帳篷，知兄長醒著，亦知兄長之怒非一言可解。然而今日沙盤上的墨色已越過了那道他心中默守的底線：若再無人出擊，萬靈坡以西的糧道將被截斷，屆時非敗北而是覆滅。他緩緩起身，向昭明道：「軍師，我有一策，請單獨稟告。」

沙盤之上血色深

西路旌旗半數沉

若問今日誰可往

滿帳沉默各低頭

唯有一人手握刃

胸中自有死生文

Jing Tong was also seated in the tent at that hour. He studied the sand-table: the gap in the western road gaped like a wound that had never been sutured, the marker-flags tilted and tattered as withered leaves. For three days he had eaten without tasting and lain awake through each night; each morning just before dawn he had gone alone to stand outside Wu Lie's tent and gaze at that tent in the morning mist, knowing his elder brother was awake, knowing equally that his elder brother's wrath could not be dissolved by any single word. Yet today the dark ink on the sand-table had crossed the threshold he had quietly kept in his heart: if no one went out to fight, the supply road west of Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope would be severed, and what awaited them then would not be defeat but annihilation. He rose slowly to his feet and said to Zhao Ming: 'Strategist, I have a proposal. I ask to speak privately.'

On the sand-table the color of blood runs deep
Half the marker-flags on the western road have fallen
Ask who today can be sent forward
The whole tent falls silent and every head bows down
Only one man sits with his hand upon his blade
In his breast there is already a text that speaks of life and death

二人屏退左右，璟同將計謀和盤托出：借吳烈之甲冑，代掛吳烈之大纛，率吳家舊部出西路急攻，以旗號迷惑墨隼，使其以為吳烈親至，必亂其陣腳；只需支撐半個時辰，昭明可遣奇兵繞至萬靈坡北麓，兩面夾擊，糧道之圍可解。昭明靜聽畢，半晌無語。窗外風吹帳壁，沙沙作響。他終於道：「此計，吳烈可允？」璟同搖頭：「不稟兄長。若稟，他必阻攔。」昭明閉目。

片刻後道：「我只問你一事：你可知萬靈坡舊稱何名？」璟同道：「不

天命輓歌



卷六

昭明道：

「前朝大戰，那坡上死了三萬人，骨頭至今染黑了土。舊稱

五十二

枯骨崗。」

昭明知而仍允，此處「允」字藏而未出，乃全書最陰之筆。計已算定，半個時辰之後，璟同在算中，昭明在

算外。

The two men dismissed those around them. Jing Tong laid out the plan in full: borrow Wu Lie's armor, hoist Wu Lie's great battle-standard, lead the Wu family's veteran troops in a swift strike down the western road. The flags and banners would deceive Mo Sun — believing Wu Lie himself had come, his formation would certainly fall into confusion. All that was needed was to hold for half an hour; in that time Zhao Ming could dispatch a flanking force around the northern foot of Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope, strike from both sides, and the siege of the supply road could be broken. Zhao Ming listened to the end without moving. For a long while he said nothing. Outside, wind pressed against the tent-wall, whispering. At last he said: 'This plan — will Wu Lie permit it?' Jing Tong shook his head: 'I will not tell my elder brother. If I tell him, he will stop me.' Zhao Ming closed his eyes. After a moment he said: 'I have one question only. Do you know what Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope was called in former times?' Jing Tong said: 'I do not.' Zhao Ming said: 'In a great battle of the previous dynasty, thirty thousand men died on that slope. The bones have blackened the soil to this day. It was called Ridge of Withered Bones.' Zhao Ming knows and still consents — the word 'consent' is swallowed unsaid, making this the darkest stroke in the entire work. The calculation is already complete. After half an hour Jing Tong will be inside the reckoning; Zhao Ming will be outside it.

璟同往吳烈帳中取甲，吳烈彼時獨坐，背對帳門，似在讀書，又似在出神。璟同推帳而入，走至甲架前，手觸那副鐵甲，冰涼如深井之水。他低聲道：「兄長，我去借一借你的甲。」吳烈頭也未回，道：「何處去？」璟同道：「演武場，試試手感。」沉默片刻，吳烈道：「拿去。」璟同取下甲冑，又取了壁上懸掛的大纛旗角，臨走時回頭望了一眼：吳烈的背影一動未動，燭光從側面打來，將那道脊背勾勒得如山如峰。璟同低下頭，走了出去。

甲冷如冰借非借

旗沉如血去不歸

兄長背影成山勢

弟目低垂出帳扉

此別無聲勝萬語

燭光獨守空帳幃

Jing Tong went to Wu Lie's tent to take the armor. Wu Lie was sitting alone at that hour, his back to the tent-entrance, appearing to read, or perhaps to stare at nothing. Jing Tong pushed aside the tent-flap and entered, crossed to the armor-stand, and laid his hand on the iron plates. They were cold as water drawn from a deep well. He said softly: 'Elder brother, I am going to borrow your armor.' Wu Lie did not turn his head. He said: 'Where are you going?' Jing Tong said: 'The training ground. To feel the weight of it.' A silence. Then Wu Lie said: 'Take it.' Jing Tong lifted down the armor and took also the corner of the great battle-standard hanging on the wall. At the threshold he looked back once: Wu Lie's figure had not moved at all. The candlelight fell across him from the side, tracing that spine against the darkness as though it were a mountain peak. Jing Tong lowered his head and walked out.

The armor cold as ice — what is borrowed will not be returned
The standard heavy as blood — what departs will not come back
The elder brother's back has become the shape of a mountain
The younger brother's eyes cast down, he passes through the tent-flap
This parting without speech outweighs ten thousand words
The candlelight alone keeps watch over the empty tent

四更天，萬靈坡以西的草地上，璟同端坐青驃馬背，身著吳烈鐵甲，腰懸彎月刀，頭頂吳家大纛獵獵於夜風之中。吳家舊部三千騎列陣於後，認得那旗，個個振奮，以為吳將軍親自出馬。璟同回首看了一眼眾人，道：「今日之事，不問緣由，只問生死。隨我衝。」言訖，驅馬向前，彎月刀出鞘，刀光如月升於黑夜。

At the fourth watch, on the grassland west of Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope, Jing Tong sat upright on the back of his blue-roan horse, wearing Wu Lie's iron armor, the crescent-moon blade at his waist, and above his head the great Wu family battle-standard snapping in the night wind. Three thousand of the Wu family's veteran cavalry were drawn up in formation behind him. They recognized the standard; every man was stirred, each believing it was General Wu who had at last come out himself. Jing Tong turned and looked back at them. He said: 'What we do today — ask no reason. Ask only of life and death. Follow me into the charge.' The words finished, he drove his horse forward. The crescent-moon blade left its scabbard, and its light rose into the black night like a moon ascending.

墨隼中軍，哨騎急報：吳烈旗出，鐵騎三千，自西路急攻而至。墨隼正與謀士對弈，聞言棋子脫手，面色驟變。他知吳烈之名久矣——沙場二十年，從未有人扛著那面旗輪過一仗。他道：「吳烈既出，今夜必有大謀，速調前後兩軍，全力迎擊，不得讓其突破。」謀士道：「殿下，是否稍作保留——」墨隼道：「不留。吳烈出陣，傾盡全力方是正道。」於是墨隼兵力盡出，如黑潮湧向西路。這正是璟同所料，亦是昭明所算。然而此後之事，已超出昭

天命輓歌
明算術之外。

此句為全書第二回「勝負已在未動之先」之回聲，然而此處算術已到其邊界。算得準者，算不準的是璟

五十五

同胸中那道義字，重逾千鈞，遠過半個時辰。

In Mo Sun's central command, a mounted scout arrived with urgent news: Wu Lie's standard had appeared, three thousand iron cavalry driving in from the western road at speed. Mo Sun was in the middle of a game of chess with his counselor. At the news the chess piece fell from his hand and his complexion changed at once. He had known Wu Lie's name for many years — twenty years on the field of battle, and no one who had ever carried that standard had lost a fight. He said: 'Since Wu Lie has come out, there is a great design behind this night — call up the vanguard and the rear forces both, commit everything to meet this thrust, do not permit a breakthrough.' The counselor said: 'Your Highness, should we perhaps hold something in reserve —' Mo Sun said: 'Nothing in reserve. When Wu Lie takes the field, full commitment is the only path.' And so Mo Sun's entire strength poured out like a black tide toward the western road. This was exactly what Jing Tong had reckoned on, and exactly what Zhao Ming had calculated. Yet what came after lay beyond the reach of Zhao Ming's arithmetic. This sentence echoes chapter two's 'the outcome is decided before a piece moves,' yet here the arithmetic has reached its limit. What the precise calculator could not calculate was the character Righteousness lodged in Jing Tong's breast, heavier than a thousand weights, far exceeding a half-hour's measure.

半個時辰後，昭明奇兵已繞至萬靈坡北麓，按計出擊，糧道之圍果然告破。傳令兵奔赴西路，攜昭明手令：「事畢，速退。」然而西路上，廝殺聲仍如雷鳴，璟同之旗未倒。昭明登高遠望，只見那面大纛仍在黑夜中搖曳，周遭已是屍山血海，而旗下之人仍在揮刀。傳令兵再入陣，回報：「璟同將軍言，敵軍尚有一部未潰，若此時撤退，退路為敵所堵，反不如殺穿。」昭明望著那旗，半晌，輕聲道了一個字：「唉。」

算盡三軍算不盡

義膽一片重如山

半個時辰早已過

旗下此人仍向前

昭明眺望無言語

此刻算術力已殫

Half an hour later, Zhao Ming's flanking force had circled to the northern foot of Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope. They struck on schedule and the siege of the supply road was broken as planned. A messenger rode to the western road carrying Zhao Ming's written order: 'The matter is accomplished. Withdraw at speed.' Yet on the western road the sounds of battle still rolled like thunder, and Jing Tong's standard had not fallen. Zhao Ming climbed to high ground and looked far out: he could see that great banner still moving through the night, surrounded by a mountain of corpses and a sea of blood, and the man beneath the banner was still swinging his blade. The messenger entered the fighting a second time and returned with word: 'General Jing Tong says there is still one enemy contingent that has not broken — if they withdraw now, the retreat route will be blocked, and it is better to cut all the way through.' Zhao Ming gazed at the standard for a long moment. Then, quietly, he let out a single syllable: 'Ah.'

Calculate to the last soldier — yet one thing eludes calculation
A heart full of righteousness weighs heavier than a mountain
The half-hour that was allotted passed long ago
And still the man beneath the standard drives forward
Zhao Ming gazes from his height and has nothing to say
In this moment his arithmetic has spent its final strength

東方天色漸白之時，萬靈坡上的廝殺聲終於沉寂。吳烈帳中，燭已燃盡，天光從帳縫中透入，照出地上一片灰燼——昭明連夜遣使，終是遣了一個字也未說的使者：只將璟同所騎青驃馬的馬鞭送入帳中，置於案上，退了出去。吳烈看見那根馬鞭，靜默良久。旋即起身，披甲，未繫甲帶，跌跌撞撞奔出帳外，翻身上馬，驅馬向西，頭也不回。

橫陳的兵器，踏過凝固成黑色的血跡。他找了很久。最後，在坡頂一株枯樹之下，他看見了璟同。璟同背靠枯樹而坐，彎月刀仍握於手，刀刃上血已半乾。吳烈下馬，走近，屈膝蹲下，以手觸璟同面頰，冰涼。那雙眼並未完全閉合，眼縫中尚留一線，望向北方，望向遠處天空漸漸亮起的地方。吳烈以指腹輕輕合上那雙眼，指尖微微顫抖，然後他將頭埋入掌中，沉默著，不哭，只是沉默著，久久不動。

When the sky to the east began to pale, the sounds of battle on Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope at last fell silent. In Wu Lie's tent the candle had burned itself out. Daylight filtered in through the gaps in the tent-wall and illuminated a patch of ash on the ground — for Zhao Ming had dispatched a messenger through the night, but in the end it was a messenger who said not a single word: he simply brought into the tent the riding whip from Jing Tong's blue-roan horse, set it on the table, and withdrew. Wu Lie looked at the whip. He was motionless for a long while. Then he rose, put on his armor without fastening the straps, and stumbled out through the tent-entrance. He swung himself onto his horse, drove it westward, and did not look back.

On Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope the morning mist had not yet lifted, and the black earth was silent as ink. Wu Lie rode slowly, passing over the heaped remains of the dead, passing over weapons strewn across the ground, passing over blood already congealed to black. He searched for a long time. At last, beneath a withered tree at the crown of the slope, he found Jing Tong. Jing Tong sat with his back against the withered tree, the crescent-moon blade still gripped in his hand, the blood on the blade half-dried. Wu Lie dismounted and drew near. He knelt down and reached out to touch Jing Tong's cheek. Cold. The eyes had not closed entirely; through the narrow gap of the lids a sliver of gaze remained, directed northward, toward the distant sky where the light was slowly, slowly growing. Wu Lie closed those eyes with the pads of his fingers, and his fingertips trembled faintly. Then he buried his face in his palms. He was silent. He did not weep. He was only silent, and he did not move for a very long time.

問鏡中人今何往兮，昔日之影誰為伴？

我曾攜手渡長河兮，兩岸蘆花白如練。

君之彎月斬千敵兮，吾之鐵甲今君穿。

甲在人去甲猶冷兮，余獨撫之淚未乾。

晨霧不知吾哀兮，枯樹不語對荒原。

昔年誓言石上刻兮，石在斯人已成煙。

義之所在君先赴兮，余困帳中守空間。

天命輓歌

卷六

是余之罪抑天命兮，此問問天天不言。

環同環同汝今在兮，萬靈坡上骨如山。

若魂有靈可歸來兮，借余一夢訴悲歡。

天命璽印誰手握兮，聯盟存亡余不管。

從今鐵甲不再穿兮，從今長刀不再彈。

唯余此身枯樹下兮，陪君骨冷至天寒。

問蒼天兮問蒼天，吾弟之死誰能還？

Where has the companion in the mirror gone — whose reflection was I?

We crossed the long river hand in hand once; on both banks the reed-flowers shone white as silk.

Your crescent blade cut down a thousand enemies; my iron armor — today you wore it.

The armor remains, the man is gone, the armor is still cold; I stroke it alone and my tears will not dry.

The morning mist does not know my grief; the withered tree says nothing, facing the waste plain.

In former years our oath was carved upon a stone; the stone remains, but the man has become smoke.

Where righteousness called, you went first; I was trapped in my tent keeping an empty vigil.

Is this my sin, or is it the Mandate of Heaven? I put the question to Heaven and Heaven does not speak.

Jing Tong, Jing Tong — where are you now? On Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope the bones rise like a mountain.

If the soul has spirit enough to return, lend me one dream and pour out the grief and the joy.

Whoever holds the Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate — whether the alliance lives or falls — I no longer care.

From this day forward the iron armor shall not be worn again; from this day forward the long blade shall not be drawn.

Only this body remains beneath the withered tree, to keep you company as your bones grow cold under a cold sky.

I cry to Heaven, I cry to Heaven — who can give back my younger brother's death?

雲素華自朱華苑遙聞戰報，提筆於記冊之上，翻至第四回所留之空白一行，凝視良久。她於第四回曾寫而又塗去：「死亡已與他相識，只是尚在耐心等待。」如今那等待已畢，那空行不再空曠，她以極細極淡之筆，一字一字填入：「萬靈坡折，璟同歿，時晨霧未散，彎月刀尚溫。吳烈至，無言，唯以甲帶繫之，負於背上，下坡。」寫至此，擱筆，不再添字。她的手微微顫著，咳了一聲，以巾掩口，取開時帕上殷紅如朱。窗外朱華苑的紅葉一片飄落，無聲而下，落入她的硯臺，將墨暈開，如血入水。

Yun Suhua, in the Vermilion Garden far away, heard the battle-dispatch and took up her brush. She turned to the blank line she had reserved in Chapter Four and gazed at it for a long while. In that chapter she had written and then rubbed out: 'Death has met him already. It is patient.' Now the patience was spent, and the blank line was blank no longer. With a brush as fine and pale as she could make it she filled the space, character by character: 'On Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope it ended — Jing Tong died, at the hour when morning mist had not yet lifted, the crescent-moon blade still faintly warm. Wu Lie arrived. He said nothing. He used the armor-strap to bind him, took him on his back, and walked down the slope.' At this she set down her brush and added nothing more. Her hand trembled faintly. She coughed once, pressed a cloth to her lips, and when she drew it away the silk was crimson as vermillion. Outside the window a red leaf from the Vermilion Garden drifted down without a sound and fell into her inkstone, spreading through the ink, as blood spreads through water.

第七回 問罪燈前 昭明垂淚

問罪燈前算無缺

沉默如國誰能出

卻說萬靈坡一役既畢，西路已定，吳烈收兵還營。璟同之喪事，昭明已命副將料理，棺木就地以青松覆蓋，暫停于坡下草廬。吳烈歸帳，默坐燈前，三日不發一語。帳中諸將輪番入稟軍情，皆悄聲報完，躡足而退，無人敢高聲。雲素華伏於帳角錄事，筆端數度停頓，硯中之墨漸幹而不知，惟見吳烈側臉如雕，燈光在其顴骨之上搖曳，照出一道深而無底的暗影。

CHAPTER 7: DEMANDING AN ACCOUNTING BY LAMPLIGHT; ZHAO MING HOLDS BACK HIS TEARS

An accounting by lamplight — the calculus is without flaw

Silence becomes a country no one can leave

After the battle at Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope was done and the western approach secured, Wu Lie drew in his troops and returned to camp. The funeral arrangements for Jing Tong had already been delegated by Zhao Ming to the deputy commanders; the coffin was laid below the slope and covered with green pine boughs in a temporary grass shelter. Wu Lie returned to his tent and sat in silence before the lamp for three days without speaking a word. The various generals entered in turn to report on military affairs, each delivering his report in a low voice before tiptoeing away — none dared to raise their voice. Yun Suhua crouched at the corner of the tent recording events; several times her brush paused, and the ink in the inkstone dried without her noticing. She could only watch Wu Lie's profile, carved and still as stone, the lamplight swaying on his cheekbones, casting a shadow deep and without a bottom.

第四日晨，一名後營小校奉命往昭明帳中問取西路圖冊，取圖歸途，與數名同袍相遇，語聲稍高，談及萬靈坡佈陣之事，有言曰：「昭明先生早料西路不保，只不過未曾知會主公罷了。」此語傳入一旁巡查之親兵耳中，親兵默然，轉身入帳，低聲告知吳烈。吳烈聽罷，閉目片刻，睜眼時面色已變，既非怒，亦非悲，乃是一種前所未有的冷靜，冷如磨刀之水，無聲而利。他只有道：「傳昭明。」

三日無言燈不滅

一語如刃破帳來

昭明自知此刻重

冬雪落地亦無聲

On the morning of the fourth day, a junior officer from the rear camp was sent to Zhao Ming's tent to retrieve the western-approach maps. On his return with the maps, he encountered several comrades, and their voices rose a little as they discussed the deployment at Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope. One of them said: 'Master Zhao Ming had long calculated that the western approach would not hold — only he had not thought to inform the lord.' These words reached the ears of a personal guard passing by on patrol. The guard said nothing. He turned and entered the tent, and in a low voice relayed what he had heard to Wu Lie. Wu Lie listened, then closed his eyes for a moment. When he opened them, his complexion had changed — it was neither rage nor grief but rather a quality of calm he had never shown before, cold as the water used to whet a blade, silent and keen. He said only: 'Summon Zhao Ming.'

Three days without speech — the lamp did not go out
A single sentence, blade-like, cuts into the tent
Zhao Ming knows the weight of this moment
Winter snow falls to the ground and makes no sound

昭明入帳，見吳烈獨坐燈前，手中無物，案上亦空，唯那一盞油燈，火焰細而穩，如審者之目。昭明長揖不語，吳烈亦不命其起，兩人如此對峙片刻。吳烈終開口，聲音平緩如問路之人，曰：「你早知西路會失？」昭明挺直了腰，答曰：「是。」吳烈再問：「你知璟同若守西路，難以生還？」昭明不動聲色，答曰：「以西路守軍之力，抵敵先鋒半個時辰，已是昭明所能推算之極限。如實回稟：弟子早知會失，亦早知守者難歸。」

帳中靜了許久，油燈芯子輕爆一聲，火焰跳了一下，復歸原形。昭明繼而言道：「昭明以西路之一人，換東路萬餘人之生路，換中路主陣之不潰，此乃戰場算術，無可更改。若主公事前知曉，必不忍壯士就死，則東路將潰，中路亦潰，兩萬人不得歸；璟同或死或俘，主公亦身陷重圍，九爐大局從此易主。彼時而論，一人之死，何輕？萬人之死，何重？」吳烈聽罷，低頭，以指節叩案一聲，道：「你說得對。」

Zhao Ming entered the tent to find Wu Lie seated alone before the lamp, his hands holding nothing, the table bare, only that single oil-lamp burning — its flame thin and steady, like the eye of an examiner. Zhao Ming bowed deeply and said nothing. Wu Lie did not bid him rise, and the two men held this posture facing each other for a moment. At last Wu Lie spoke. His voice was even, like a man asking directions on a road: 'You knew from the start that the western approach would fall?' Zhao Ming straightened his spine and answered: 'Yes.' Wu Lie asked again: 'You knew that if Jing Tong held the western approach, he would not likely return alive?' Zhao Ming did not change his expression. He answered: 'For the forces assigned to hold the western approach to resist the enemy vanguard for half an hour — that was the outermost limit of what this disciple could calculate as possible. To report honestly: I had known from the beginning that it would fall, and had known from the beginning that the one who held it would not come back.'

The tent was silent for a long time. The lamp-wick crackled softly once; the flame leapt and then settled back to its original shape. Zhao Ming continued: 'By sacrificing one man on the western approach, this counselor won the path of life for more than ten thousand men on the eastern flank, and prevented the collapse of the central formation. This is the arithmetic of the battlefield; it cannot be altered. Had my lord known in advance, he would not have been able to bear sending a brave warrior to his death — the eastern flank would have broken, the center would have broken, twenty thousand men would not have returned. Jing Tong might have died or been captured regardless, and my lord too would have been encircled and overwhelmed, and the great situation of the Nine Furnaces would have changed hands from that hour. Weighed against that outcome — is one death light? Are ten thousand deaths heavy?' Wu Lie heard him out, bowed his head, and struck the table once with his knuckle. He said: 'You are right.'

然吳烈未曾停歇，抬起眼，目光直視昭明，徐徐又道：「那萬餘人，如今可有一人，知曉璟同之名？」此語一出，昭明面色微變，沉默如壁。吳烈不等他答，亦不再追問，只轉目望向燈焰，復不言語。一室之中，唯有燈光搖曳，映出兩個人的影子，一靜一顫，皆如墨痕。昭明立於原地，忽覺目中有物，強壓之，壓之不住，低首時，一滴落於靴前青石地板，無聲碎散，如那一場算術中從未被書寫的名字。

此一句乃全書之錐心之語。算術能算存亡，卻算不得姓名；昭明之術既

萬人歸路一人開

算盤精絕笑塵埃

十萬姓名書不盡

獨缺璟同兩字來

Yet Wu Lie did not stop. He raised his eyes and looked directly at Zhao Ming, speaking slowly once more: 'Among those ten thousand men — does even one of them know Jing Tong's name?' At these words Zhao Ming's complexion shifted almost imperceptibly. He was silent as a wall. Wu Lie did not wait for an answer, nor did he press the question further; he simply turned his gaze back to the lamp's flame and said nothing more. In the room there was only the lamp swaying, casting the shadows of two men — one still, one trembling — both like traces of ink. Zhao Ming stood in place, and suddenly felt something rise in his eyes. He pressed it down; it would not be pressed. When he bowed his head, one drop fell onto the green stone floor before his boots, scattering soundlessly — like a name that had never been written into that piece of battlefield arithmetic.

This sentence is the line that pierces to the heart of the entire work. Arithmetic can calculate survival and extinction, but it cannot calculate a name. Zhao Ming's craft, precise and solitary, collapses entirely at this moment. The commentator sets down the brush and cannot continue for a long while.

The road home for ten thousand men was opened by one man

The abacus flawless — and yet it laughs at nothing but dust

Ten thousand names the ledger cannot finish writing

Only these two words — Jing Tong — are absent from the page

事後，吳烈既不解除昭明之職，亦不革除其參議之權，更不逐之出帳。他只是此後不再與昭明同席用膳，不再獨召昭明夜議，凡有戰事，傳令之人來去皆是副將，昭明之謀略照舊施行，吳烈之令照舊採納，然二人之間多出一片空地，空地之上無有風雨，無有日光，無有話語，唯有那一個問句，懸於其上，不落不散。昭明心知此乃重罰，重於奪官，重於廷杖，重於一切可名狀之懲處，因此懲處乃以沉默為刃，深入而無形。

吳烈之沉默，非一人之沉默，乃一國之沉

不革不逐不加刑

只是從今各自行

帳中兩燈原共焰

此後照各半壁冰

Afterward, Wu Lie neither relieved Zhao Ming of his post nor stripped him of his advisory authority, nor drove him from the tent. It was simply that from then onward Wu Lie no longer shared a table with Zhao Ming at meals, no longer summoned him alone for night consultations; in all military matters it was a deputy commander who carried orders back and forth. Zhao Ming's stratagems were implemented as before; Wu Lie's commands continued to draw upon them. Yet between the two men a vacant ground had opened — a ground without wind or rain, without sunlight, without words — only that one question, hanging suspended above it, neither falling nor dispersing. Zhao Ming understood that this was a heavy punishment: heavier than stripping rank, heavier than the court rod, heavier than any penalty that could be named, because this punishment used silence as its blade, cutting deep and leaving no visible wound. Wu Lie's silence is not the silence of one man but the silence of a country. Zhao Ming can neither argue, nor escape, nor atone. From this point onward he walks through the Nine Furnaces carrying that question on his person — like a cangue, like a shadow.

No dismissal, no exile, no punishment pronounced
Only that from this day forward each moves through the world alone
Two lamps in the tent that once shared a single flame
Hereafter each illuminates its own half-wall of ice

是月下旬，霧胤遣使持白旗入吳烈大營。使者言，霧胤亦傷亡慘重，糧草不繼，天命璽雖在其手，然玄璽不能果腹，玄璽不能行軍，霧胤願暫罷干戈，兩軍各守現有疆界，璽之歸屬，來日再議。吳烈召昭明及諸將議事，帳中意見各異，主戰者有之，主和者有之。昭明陳言：「乘勝追擊，固可一鼓；然吾軍亦疲，璟同既歿，西路空虛，此時強攻，勝算不足六分，若再一折，九爐大局恐難挽回。臣以為，暫息可也。」吳烈聽罷，領首，下令與霧胤暫時

In the latter part of that month, Wu Yin sent an emissary bearing a white banner into Wu Lie's main camp. The emissary reported that Wu Yin too had suffered heavy casualties and could no longer sustain his supply lines. The Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate was in his hands, but the Seal could not fill an empty belly and could not lead troops on the march; Wu Yin was willing to lay down arms for the time being, each army to hold its present territory, and the question of the Seal's ultimate disposition to be settled another day. Wu Lie summoned Zhao Ming and the assembled generals to deliberate in the tent. Opinion in the tent was divided: some urged pressing the attack while victory was momentum, others urged acceptance of the truce. Zhao Ming spoke: 'To strike while the momentum is ours — yes, we could do it with a single drum-beat. Yet our army is also exhausted; with Jing Tong gone, the western approach is hollow; to assault now, our odds of success do not reach six in ten. If we suffer another setback, the great situation of the Nine Furnaces may be beyond recovery. This counselor holds that a temporary halt is acceptable.' Wu Lie heard him out, inclined his head, and issued the order to accept a temporary ceasefire with Wu Yin, marking the boundary with standing stones.

休戰文書既定，使者去後，諸將各散。帳中唯餘吳烈與雲素華。素華收起筆硯，起身欲退，吳烈忽曰：「素華，你可知世界之西邊，盡頭是何所在？」

素華愕然，回首見吳烈正目視帳頂，神情遙遠，如在問天。她思忖片刻，輕聲答道：「古籍有載，崑崙之西，過流沙千里，有山名曰昏冥，山後即是天地之罅，日月沉落之處，此後便無路可循。」吳烈聞言，微微頷首，不再言語，目光仍向帳頂，而素華卻知，他問的不是地理，他問的是璟同去了哪

西山落鏡無人收

鏡中何面映空秋

萬靈坡上草猶在

不見持鏡人回頭

Once the ceasefire documents were settled and the emissary had departed, the generals dispersed one by one. In the tent only Wu Lie and Yun Suhua remained. Suhua was gathering her brush and inkstone, preparing to withdraw, when Wu Lie suddenly said: 'Suhua — do you know what lies at the far edge of the world, to the west?' Suhua was startled. She turned to find Wu Lie gazing at the top of the tent, his expression distant, as if he were putting the question to the sky. She considered for a moment and then answered softly: 'The ancient texts record that west of the Kunlun, beyond a thousand leagues of drifting sand, there is a mountain called Dark Oblivion; beyond that mountain is the fissure between heaven and earth, the place where the sun and moon descend — and beyond that, the texts say, there is no road to follow.' Wu Lie heard her, inclined his head gently, and said nothing more, his gaze still lifted to the top of the tent. But Suhua knew: what he was asking was not a question of geography. He was asking where Jing Tong had gone — and whether there was any road he himself might take to follow.

In the western hills a mirror has fallen — no one gathers it up
Within the mirror, whose face reflects the empty autumn
On Ten-Thousand-Spirit Slope the grass is still growing
But the one who held the mirror does not turn his head and come back

此後數日，吳烈私下多番遣人詢訪：西行之路，可有嚮導；流沙之地，可有古道；昏冥山之名，舊籍何處有載。問者皆以為主公謀劃西征，殫精竭慮，回報甚詳。吳烈一一覽畢，疊置案頭，不置可否。雲素華錄事至此，放下筆，於簿末寫道：「吳烈問西路。非軍事，此人心事也。英雄而問死者之路，非因貪生，乃因不忍死別。吾恐此後，朱華苑中，所錄之事，多有不忍卒讀者。」寫畢，合簿，窗外無風，舊梅枝上忽墜一點積雪，無聲落入庭

天命輓歌
轉眼消融，如從未有過。

In the days that followed, Wu Lie privately sent men more than once to make inquiries: whether there were guides for the road going westward, whether ancient tracks existed across the lands of drifting sand, in which old texts the name Dark Oblivion Mountain could be found. Those sent on these errands assumed their lord was planning a western campaign and reported back in exhaustive detail. Wu Lie read through each report in turn, stacked them on the table, and gave no judgment either way. At this point Yun Suhua, recording events, set down her brush. At the end of the page she wrote: 'Wu Lie asks about the western road. This is not a military matter; it is this man's private grief. That a hero should ask after the road where the dead have gone — it is not because he clings to life, but because he cannot endure the finality of parting in death. I fear that from this point onward, what must be recorded within the Vermilion Garden will often be too painful to read through to the end.' When she had finished writing she closed the ledger. Outside the window there was no wind, but on the bare branch of the old plum a clot of snow suddenly fell — dropping in silence to the courtyard, dissolving in an instant, as if it had never been.

英雄問路向西天

問路非因恐死期

一諾重於山河在

義兄先去路誰知

素華合簿燈亦滅

雪落無聲苑自悲

天命輓歌

卷七

天命輓歌，第七回既畢。璟同之死，沉入九爐山河之底，無人撈起；昭明之

六十八

算，懸於帳中高處，無人觸碰；吳烈之沉默，蔓延為一片版圖，出入者皆被其籠罩，無有脫身之法。天命璽仍在霧胤手中，戰未終，勝未定，敗未明，唯有那條通往世界西端的道路，開始在吳烈心中成形，一寸一寸，如石縫中生長之草，無聲而執意。欲知後事如何，且看下回分解。

The hero asks after the road that leads to the far west of heaven
He asks not because he fears the hour of death
An oath weighs heavier than mountains and rivers standing
The sworn elder brother has gone ahead — who knows by which road
Suhua closes the ledger and the lamp too goes out
Snow falls without a sound; the garden mourns by itself

The Elegy of the Mandate: Chapter 7 now concludes. Jing Tong's death has sunk to the bed of the Nine Furnaces' mountains and rivers — no one will raise it up again. Zhao Ming's calculation hangs high in the tent — no one will touch it. Wu Lie's silence has spread into a territory of its own; all who enter or depart are enveloped within it, and none have found the way to step free. The Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate remains in Wu Yin's hands; the war is not ended, victory is not certain, and defeat is not yet clear. Only that road leading to the western edge of the world has begun to take shape in Wu Lie's heart — inch by inch, like grass growing through a crack in stone: without sound, and without the intention to stop. As for what followed — that awaits the telling of the next chapter.

第八回 西行問鬼 忘川授路

西行人獨踏荒草

忘川水深問無聲

卻說吳烈自璟同歿後，沉默如一口廢井，深而無響。朝中諸事，悉委昭明主持；軍務諸令，皆令副將代行。世人見之，或以為其傷痛已過，殊不知靜水之下，萬壑俱在。某夜，烈獨立城頭，望西天雲色如鐵，忽心中有一念倏起：璟同在哪處？非詩人之問，乃武者之問——刀問向西，腳步便西去。翌日天明，城門尚閉，守卒見一人獨行，背負短刀，步履如常，面無表情，以為流放之犯或遊蕩之鬼，皆閃道旁，不敢攔問。吳烈遂西行，無人相送，無旗無號，如石投入水，世界悄然合攏其後。

CHAPTER 8: TRAVELLING WEST TO QUESTION THE DEAD; THE RIVER OF FORGETTING GRANTS A ROAD

Westward the lone man treads the withered grass

The River of Forgetting runs deep; his questions find no voice

After Jing Tong died, Wu Lie fell silent as an abandoned well — deep and without echo. The affairs of court he left entirely to Zhao Ming; military orders he delegated to his lieutenants. Those who observed him thought perhaps his grief had passed, not knowing that beneath still water a thousand gorges persist. One night Wu Lie stood alone on the city wall, watching the western sky where clouds massed dark as iron. A thought rose in him without warning: where is Jing Tong? Not a poet's question — a warrior's question. His blade turned west; his feet followed. At the next dawn, while the city gates were still shut, the gate-guards saw a lone man departing, a short sword at his back, his stride unhurried, his face empty of expression. They took him for a convict sent into exile, or a wandering ghost. They stepped aside and did not dare stop him or ask. Wu Lie went west. No one saw him off; no banner, no drum. Like a stone dropped into water, the world closed quietly behind him.

行數日，地形漸異。道路初似尋常荒野，繼而草色轉白，繼而草中有聲，低如嚙語，細聽之，乃人語，然語序顛倒，詞義散亂，如被水浸泡過久之書帛，字跡猶在而意思已失。吳烈蹲身，俯耳於草，辨出一句：「……娘……鍋裡……還有……」，又一句：「……別，別走……」，又一句支離不可辨認。他明白了——此乃死者臨終之言，散落此地，在草莖間反覆呢喃，如磁片碎於地，仍依稀記得舊日之歌。烈於草地中站立良久，向西南方空氣中輕起，彷彿有人轉身。

天命輓歌
聲道

卷八

「璟同，你走過這裡麼？你說了什麼？」無人回答，然身後草浪忽

七十

白草無邊聲細碎，死人遺語纏草根。

半句慈母呼兒名，一聲新婦喚郎魂。

英雄側耳聽不得，西風過處舊情痕。

璟同，璟同，汝何在？草答以沉默，又答以聲音。

After several days' travel the terrain began to change. The road at first resembled ordinary wilderness; then the colour of the grass shifted to white; then voices rose from within the grass — low as the murmuring of sleep. Listening closely, Wu Lie heard human speech, but the order of words was inverted, meanings scattered, like writing on silk left too long in water: the characters still present, the sense already gone. He crouched down and pressed his ear to the grass. He made out one phrase: '... mother ... the pot ... there is still ...' and another: '... don't, don't go ...' and then fragments too broken to decipher. He understood. These were the last words of the dead, scattered across this place, repeating endlessly among the grass-stems — like shards of a bronze mirror that still dimly remember the songs they once reflected. Wu Lie stood for a long time in the white grass, then spoke quietly toward the air to the southwest: 'Jing Tong — did you pass through here? What did you say?' No answer came. Yet the grass behind him surged in a wave, as though someone had turned around.

Boundless white grass, and within it, fine-grained sounds — the last words of the dead tangled among the roots.

Half a phrase: a loving mother calling her child's name. One cry: a young bride summoning her husband's soul.

The hero presses his ear close, but cannot hold the words; the west wind passes and leaves only the trace of old feeling.

Jing Tong, Jing Tong — where are you now? The grass answers with silence; then answers again with sound.

又行數日，前方現一城，然此城甚奇——樓宇整齊，街道筆直，門牌號碼分明，然無一扇門開著，無一窗內有燈，卻有人——無數人，魚貫成列，立於各衙署之外，或坐或站，神情漠然，各執一紙牌，上書所求之事：「申請戶籍核發」、「亡人名錄更正申請」、「魂籍遷移手續辦理」。窗口後有吏員，然吏員皆低頭，翻弄文書，永不抬頭。隊列緩緩移動，然每有人近至窗口，吏員便搖頭曰：「此窗非辦此事，請往第七窗。」第七窗之吏員復曰：

天命輓歌

卷八

此窗今日停辦，明日請早。」然此地無明日。吳烈穿隊列而過，死者皆讓

七十一

道，以目光相送，目光中無怨怒，只有無邊倦意。

此段寫幽都衙署，表面荒誕，實則深

刻。死者猶排隊求辦手續，此乃人世執念之延伸，非鬼怪可怖，乃官僚之永恆。批者以為，此城較十八層地獄更令人心寒。

Several more days of walking, and ahead a city appeared. But it was a strange city: its buildings were orderly, its streets straight, the number-plaques on every door clearly marked. Yet not one door stood open, not one window showed a lamp. There were people — countless people, filing in queues outside every government office, some sitting, some standing, their expressions blank. Each held a paper tablet inscribed with their petition: 'Application for household registry issuance.' 'Request to correct an error in the register of the deceased.' 'Processing of soul-registry relocation procedures.' Behind the counter-windows sat clerks, but the clerks all kept their heads bowed, sorting through documents, never once looking up. The queues moved slowly forward. But whenever someone drew close enough to reach a window, the clerk would shake his head and say: 'This window does not handle that matter — please proceed to Window Seven.' The clerk at Window Seven would in turn reply: 'This window has suspended service for today; please come early tomorrow.' Yet in this place there was no tomorrow. Wu Lie passed through the queues; the dead made way for him, watching him go with their eyes. In those eyes there was no anger, no resentment — only an exhaustion without end. 'This window does not handle that matter' — on its surface absurdist, yet deeply felt. The dead still queue to petition for procedures; this is the continuation of the living world's attachments into death. Not a horror of demons, but the eternal horror of bureaucracy. The commentator finds this city colder to the heart than all eighteen hells.

城之西南隅，有一山。白晝望之，山勢巍峨，巖壁陡峭，似可攀登，然近之則覺有異：山石紋路過於規整，苔蘚分佈如以尺量過，陽光打上去，反光之角度微有不對。吳烈手撫石面，冰涼光滑，無一粒沙礫。他繞山一周，至背陰處，見一板壁之縫，手指探入，摸得畫布之質。此山乃畫。不知何人，以極大手筆，繪一座山于此，遠觀無異，近觸則假。吳烈仰頭，對著畫山苦笑：「連山也是假的。璟同若在，必大笑一場。」待至夜，四周一片暗，月

天命輓歌



卷八

山形消失，然腳下卻有實實在在的石階，向上延伸，無盡頭。他遂於夜中攀山，每步皆實，但不可回頭看——曾有一次回頭，身後只有虛空，黑暗，以及極遠處某個城市的昏黃燈火。

晝山是晝夜山真，英雄攀行不回頭。
一步一石皆有據，身後空茫無去路。
璟同笑聲在何處？唯有夜風答山谷。

At the southwestern corner of the city stood a mountain. Seen by daylight, it was imposing in scale: sheer cliffs, a commanding silhouette, apparently climbable. Yet drawing close, something felt wrong. The grain of the rock was too regular; the distribution of moss seemed measured by a ruler; sunlight striking the surface reflected back at a slightly incorrect angle. Wu Lie pressed his hand against the stone — cold and smooth, not a single grain of grit. He circled the mountain entirely, and on the shaded side found a crack in a flat surface. He pushed a finger into the crack and felt the texture of painted canvas. The mountain was a painting. Someone, with brush-strokes of enormous scale, had painted a mountain here. Distant, it was indistinguishable from the real. Close, it was false. Wu Lie looked up at the painted mountain and gave a bitter smile. 'Even the mountains here are false. If Jing Tong were here, he would laugh himself hoarse.' When night came and darkness settled over everything, the mountain's silhouette vanished in the darkness — yet beneath Wu Lie's feet there appeared a staircase of entirely solid stone, extending upward without visible end. He climbed the mountain in the dark. Every step was real. But he could not look back. Once, he glanced behind him, and there was only void, only darkness, and in the very far distance the dim yellow glow of a city's lamps.

By day the mountain is a painting; by night it is real — the hero climbs and does not look back.

Each step, each stone has its substance; behind him is only void, with no road back.

Where now is the sound of Jing Tong's laughter? Only the night wind answers, returning from the valley.

山頂之後，地勢驟降，前方有水聲，低沉如嗆咽，非奔流，乃漫淌——忘川也。河面寬闊，水色灰白，若融雪初解而水中攪了塵，不見河底，不見對岸，然有橋，橋上有一老者，背漁蓑，持竹竿，不釣魚，只把竿垂于水中，一動不動，彷彿他本人亦是水中之物，只是尚未沉下去。吳烈近前，老者不動，不看他。吳烈立于橋頭，道：「老丈，此橋可通對岸？」老者曰：「可通。」吳烈道：「敢問可否渡我？」老者曰：「先問你一事。你怕什麼？」

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卷八

吳烈不假思索，答曰：「無所懼。」老者沉默半晌，旋轉過身，第一次看

七十三

他，目光如積年之水，深而無底，道：「此乃你今日所言最真之語，亦是最不誠之語。渡。」

河神此語，看似矛盾，實乃洞見。吳烈言「無所懼」，其果無懼乎？正因懼得太深，反言無懼。

老子曰「知常曰明」，河神知其常，故明之。批者以為此一問答乃全章之樞紐。

Beyond the mountaintop the land dropped sharply, and ahead Wu Lie heard the sound of water — low, like stifled weeping, not a rushing torrent but a wide, slow spread. The River of Forgetting. The river's surface was broad and grey-white, like meltwater from the first thaw mixed with the dust of years. No bottom was visible, no opposite bank — yet there was a bridge, and on the bridge an old man, wearing a rain-cape of straw, holding a bamboo pole. He was not fishing; he simply let the pole trail in the water and sat motionless, as though he himself were also a thing of the water, only not yet sunk beneath it. Wu Lie approached. The old man did not stir, did not look up. Wu Lie stood at the bridgehead and said: 'Old father — does this bridge cross to the far bank?' The old man said: 'It does.' Wu Lie said: 'May I ask whether you will ferry me across?' The old man said: 'First I ask you one thing. What do you fear?' Without hesitation Wu Lie answered: 'Nothing.' The old man was silent for a long moment. Then he turned, and for the first time he looked at Wu Lie directly. His gaze was like water accumulated over years — deep and without bottom. He said: 'This is the truest thing you have said today, and also the most dishonest. Cross.'

The River-God's reply seems contradictory but is in fact insight. Wu Lie says 'I fear nothing' — does he truly fear nothing? It is precisely because his fear runs so deep that he names its absence. Laozi wrote: 'knowing the constant is called clarity.' The River-God knows his constant, and so sees clearly. The commentator holds this exchange to be the pivot of the entire chapter.

忘川水深無底色，老者垂竿不問魚。

英雄立橋言無懼，河神一笑水紋起。

真語假語同一言，此岸彼岸同此日。

渡者須知渡非渡，過水之人已非昨日吾。

過橋，地色轉深，前方隱現城廓，非大城，乃省城氣象——矮牆灰瓦，牌坊幾座，街燈昏黃，光圈之內皆是浮塵。此即幽都，天下亡魂之暫居之所也。

天命輓歌

入城之初

，有吏執冊核查，見吳烈，翻冊半晌，搖頭曰：「無此人名錄。」

七十四

烈曰：「吾非死者，乃生人。」吏員瞪目，又翻冊，道：「生人無此例，然亦無明文禁止。暫予登記，列為『未定類』，請勿製造糾紛，勿滯留逾期。」烈領牌入城，牌上寫：「訪客（存疑）。」城中死者見之，多不理睬，少數側目，更少數者低聲相告：「生人。」如報一異鳥入林，無驚，只有遠遠的好奇。

The River of Forgetting, deep and colourless to its bed; the old man trails his pole and does not seek fish.

The hero stands on the bridge and declares he has no fear; the River-God smiles once, and the water's surface stirs.

True speech and false speech are a single utterance; this bank and that bank share the same unmoving day.

Whoever would cross must know that crossing is not crossing — the man who has passed through water is no longer yesterday's self.

After crossing, the colour of the ground deepened, and ahead the outline of a city gradually appeared — not a great capital but a provincial city in character: low walls, grey roof-tiles, a few memorial archways, street-lamps burning dim yellow, their circles of light filled with drifting dust. This was the Dark Metropolis — the temporary dwelling-place of all the departed souls under heaven. At the city's entrance, a clerk with a register checked arrivals. He saw Wu Lie, turned through the register for a long moment, then shook his head: 'No entry for this name.' Wu Lie said: 'I am not among the dead. I am a living person.' The clerk stared, turned through the register again, and said: 'There is no precedent for a living person, but there is no written prohibition either. You will be registered provisionally, categorized as Undetermined Class. Please do not cause disturbances. Do not overstay.' Wu Lie was issued a tablet and entered the city. The tablet read: Visitor (Status Uncertain). The dead inside the city mostly paid him no attention. A few glanced sideways. Fewer still murmured quietly to one another: 'A living person.' As one might report an unusual bird entering a forest — no alarm, only a distant, mild curiosity.

吳烈於幽都中尋璟同，問於各處。然幽都之大，遠超人想——街道縱橫，巷弄深曲，每一巷皆有數百戶，每一戶皆有其亡者，各自沉默，各坐門前，如在等一封永不投到的信。有老嫗抬頭，問曰：「汝尋何人？」烈曰：「友人，名璟同，壯年，體形高大，笑聲如雷。」嫗搖頭曰：「此處無此人，此人笑聲太響，幽都不留響聲之人——響聲之人，皆送往更深之檔案。」烈問：「何謂更深之檔案？」嫗默然，以手向城之更深處一指，旋低頭，不再

Wu Lie moved through the Dark Metropolis searching for Jing Tong, making inquiries at every turning. But the Dark Metropolis was vaster than any living person could conceive: streets crossing in every direction, lanes twisting deep into shadow, each lane holding hundreds of households, each household its own dead person sitting in their own silence before their own door — as though waiting for a letter that would never be delivered. An old woman raised her head and asked: 'Whom are you looking for?' Wu Lie said: 'A friend — name of Jing Tong, a man in his prime, large in frame, with a laugh like thunder.' The old woman shook her head. 'There is no such person here. His laugh was too loud. The Dark Metropolis does not keep those who carry loud sounds — people who carry loud sounds are all sent to the deeper archive.' Wu Lie asked: 'What is the deeper archive?' The old woman was silent. She raised one hand and pointed toward the city's further interior, then lowered her head and paid him no more attention.

我追不上^{卷八}的地方了。但我還是來了。你能聽見麼？」無聲。然廣場上數片枯

葉，忽無風而動。

吳烈又行，至城中一廣場，廣場正中有一石碑，高丈餘，碑面密密麻麻刻滿名字——皆亡者之名，字跡工整，然排列無序，非依生卒，非依姓氏，唯依一種無法解讀的邏輯羅列，如一部無目錄之書。烈於碑前細尋，尋至日落（雖此處之日落只是燈光稍稍再暗一些），未見璟同之名。忽見碑角有一行小字，刻曰：「已移往前檔者，不列此碑。」旁有一更小注：「前檔即檔中之無盡處。」吳烈默讀此語，閉目，在碑前向空氣中說：「璟同，你已走到

Wu Lie walked on until he reached a wide square at the city's centre. In the middle of the square stood a stone stele, over ten feet high, its surface covered in densely carved names — names of the departed, the calligraphy neat and regular, but arranged in no discernible order: not by date of birth or death, not by surname, only by some logic that could not be read, like a book without a table of contents. Wu Lie searched the stele face carefully, searching until what passed for sunset in this place — which meant only that the lamps dimmed slightly further. He found no name of Jing Tong. Then at the stele's corner he noticed one line of smaller characters carved there: 'Those transferred to the Forward Archive are not listed on this stele.' Beside it, in an even smaller annotation: 'The Forward Archive is the place within the archive that has no end.' Wu Lie read these words in silence. He closed his eyes. Standing before the stele, he spoke into the air: 'Jing Tong — you have gone somewhere I cannot follow. And yet I came anyway. Can you hear me?' Silence. Yet on the square's stone pavement, several dry leaves moved without wind.

幽都賦

維幽都之在西，地廣而氣昏兮，

街衢整肅，牌匾列兮，燈火如故而無溫兮。

亡者就列，手執牒兮，案無決斷，隊無盡兮。

吏員低首，印不落兮，申請年年，歲月空兮。

生者偶入，目皆側兮，訪客存疑，牌繫頸兮。

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▼卷八
景司不在此城中，笑響已移深檔閣兮。

吳烈立碑，問虛空兮，葉動無風，或有聲兮。

嗚呼，幽都之法度嚴而其情淡，

其序整而其意冷，其名眾而其人失——

非地獄之恐怖，乃省府之永晝兮。

Rhapsody of the Dark Metropolis

The Dark Metropolis lies to the west; the land is wide and the air dim.

Its avenues are orderly, its plaques hang in rows; its lamps burn as always, but give no warmth.

The dead form their queues, each holding a document; no case is decided, no queue reaches its end.

The clerks keep their heads bowed; the seal does not descend; petitions accumulate year on year; time passes empty.

When a living person enters, every eye turns sideways; tagged as Visitor, Status Uncertain, the tablet hangs at the neck.

Jing Tong is not in this city — his laugh was too loud; it has been moved to the deeper archive.

Wu Lie stands before the stele and questions the void; leaves stir without wind, as though something, perhaps, makes sound.

Alas — the Dark Metropolis is strict in its ordinances and thin in feeling;

ordered in its arrangements yet cold in its intent; its roster of names is vast, yet its persons are lost

—

not the terror of hell, but the permanent noon of a provincial office.

是夜，吳烈宿於城中一客舍——幽都亦有客舍，供偶入之生人或未定類者暫住，被褥灰薄，枕頭重如石，窗外有隊伍徹夜排列，腳步聲無聲，然隱約可感地板之震顫。烈不能眠，坐於燈下，取懷中帛書，以炭筆寫字，非給雲素華之記錄，乃給璟同之書信，無收信人，無署名，寫道：「吾至幽都，未見汝，聞汝已在更深之處。吾不知何謂更深，然明日將繼續向西。汝若尚有知覺，勿等吾，先走。吾只是要告訴汝：桃林之誓，吾仍記。」寫畢，折好，

天命輓歌
置於燈焰旁，

卷八

頃刻成灰。灰升，散於屋內，無去向。

此語回應第一回桃林結義，首尾呼

七十八

應，情深一至於此。信燒於幽都，灰散無歸，此寫法與古人焚紙以祭之俗暗合，然烈所燒者非祭品，乃心聲——比祭品更重，亦更

難收。

燒一紙書與璟同，灰飛無聲落幽都。
桃林血誓猶在口，幽都無人能作主。
生者書信死者讀，不知冥路幾多途。

That night Wu Lie lodged at an inn within the city — for the Dark Metropolis had inns, built to accommodate the occasional living visitor or Undetermined guest. The bedding was thin and grey; the pillow was heavy as stone. Outside the window, queues continued to form through the night: their footsteps made no sound, yet the faint trembling of the floorboards beneath could be felt. Wu Lie could not sleep. He sat beneath the lamp, drew the silk-cloth from his chest, and wrote with a charcoal brush. Not the record he kept for Yun Suhua — this was a letter to Jing Tong. No recipient, no sender. He wrote: 'I have reached the Dark Metropolis. I did not find you. I am told you have gone somewhere deeper. I do not know what deeper means, but tomorrow I will continue westward. If you still have awareness of any kind, do not wait for me. Go ahead. I only needed to tell you: the oath in the peach grove — I still hold it.' When he finished, he folded the letter carefully and placed it beside the lamp's flame. In a moment it was ash. The ash rose, dispersed through the room, and had nowhere to go. *This line echoes the oath sworn in the peach grove of Chapter 1 — head and tail answering each other across the full span. A letter burned in the Dark Metropolis, its ash dispersing with nowhere to go: the method secretly accords with the old custom of burning paper offerings for the dead. But what Wu Lie burns is not an offering — it is the voice of his heart. Heavier than any offering, and harder to retrieve.*

He burns a paper letter for Jing Tong; the ash falls without sound in the Dark Metropolis.

The blood-oath of the peach grove still lives in his mouth, yet in the Dark Metropolis no one holds authority over such things.

A living man's letter, read by one who is dead — and no one knows how many roads the dark passage holds.

天將明未明之際，吳烈起身，出客舍，穿城而過，向城之更西處行去。城門守吏核査牌符，見「訪客（存疑）」，翻冊，道：「逾期一夜，罰錄一筆，請簽字。」烈簽字，吏員在冊上添一行小字，無人知是何字。出城之時，烈忽轉身，望幽都昏黃之燈火，低聲道：「無言君，我知此城是你的轄境。」

此名，乃西極之女神，主宰更深冥界者——他未見她，然城中一呼一吸皆似含她之意志。說完，他轉身西行，幽都之燈在身後漸漸淡去，如一場尚未說

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完便
卷八
終止的夢，或一段話，說到一半，發聲者忽然閉口，而聽者仍立在那

處，等待那未曾到來的下半句。

When the sky was poised between dark and light, Wu Lie rose, left the inn, passed through the city, and walked westward toward the city's further boundary. The gate-guard checked his tablet: seeing 'Visitor, Status Uncertain,' he turned through the register and said: 'You have overstayed by one night. A demerit notation will be added. Please sign.' Wu Lie signed. The clerk added a line of small characters to the register; no one could tell what the characters said. As he stepped through the gate, Wu Lie turned once and looked back at the dim yellow lamps of the Dark Metropolis. He said, quietly: 'Lady Silence — I know this city is within your jurisdiction.' This name: the goddess of the western extreme, sovereign of the deeper reaches of the dark — he had not seen her, yet every breath the city drew seemed to carry something of her will. He finished speaking, turned, and walked west. The lamps of the Dark Metropolis faded behind him, gradually, like a dream that ends before it has finished speaking, or like a sentence, broken off at its midpoint, the speaker having suddenly gone silent while the listener still stands there, waiting for the second half that never comes.

第九回 不死之淵 玄母示價

不死之水飲者悲

無言之母示真機

卻說吳烈孤身抵達天下之盡，玄都入夜後如墨染，城闕無燈，然行路自明，光從何來，不可知也。無言君端坐深殿之中，其前已有人等候多時。殿無

香，無火，無侍從之聲，唯四壁隱透一種幽藍，如水底望天。吳烈步入時，

天命輓歌



卷九

膝下忽覺沉重，非恐懼所致，乃此地重力本異於人間，每一步皆叫人想起自

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身之重——所有過往之事，所有尚未忘卻之人，盡壓於肩上，無聲無形，重於甲冑。

CHAPTER 9: THE WATER OF UNDYING; LADY SILENCE SHOWS ITS PRICE

The water that will not die brings grief to the one who drinks

The mother of silence reveals the true mechanism

Wu Lie had come alone to the world's uttermost edge. After nightfall the Dark Metropolis was ink-dyed through: its towers and gates bore no lanterns, yet the road showed itself clearly — from what source the light came, none could say. Lady Silence sat upright in the innermost hall, where someone had long been expected. The hall held no incense, no fire, no sound of attendants; only the four walls breathed a deep blue luminescence, as if one looked up at the sky from the bottom of water. As Wu Lie stepped inside, a heaviness descended on his knees — not from fear, but because the gravity of this place differed fundamentally from the world of the living. Every step made him conscious of his own weight: all that had passed, all those he had not yet managed to forget, pressed upon his shoulders without shape or sound, heavier than armour.

無言君不語。吳烈亦不語。半晌，吳烈開口，言辭較來路上所預備者少了許多。他只說：「吾有一問。」無言君闔目，以靜作答。吳烈又道：「不死之水，果有其物乎？」無言君啟眸，目光如淵，不含褒貶，只是望他——如鏡面望人，映出者不是容顏，而是問題本身，問問者為何而問，問者之心，究竟藏著何物。吳烈被那目光照入，心中諸般說辭忽然散去，剩下的不過是一個赤裸的事實：璟同已死。昭明在世。雲素華在世。自己還在。這便是他前

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卷九
來的緣由，全部。

無言君之眼，實是作者之眼也。此處鏡喻，非照容顏，乃照動機——吳烈欲求不死，其底下藏

八十一

者，乃不敢再失之心。批者按：人之所求，往往非其所言，無言君先知此理，故以沉默問之。

英雄千里來一問，問在唇邊意已違。

鏡中無顏映者何，悲字未出淚先歸。

Lady Silence did not speak. Wu Lie did not speak. After a long while, Wu Lie opened his mouth, and the words were far fewer than those he had prepared along the road. He said only: 'I have one question.' Lady Silence closed her eyes and answered with stillness. Wu Lie continued: 'The Water of Undying — does such a thing truly exist?' Lady Silence opened her eyes. Her gaze was deep as an abyss, without judgement of any kind; she simply looked at him — as a mirror-surface looks at a person, reflecting not the face but the question itself, and the reason the questioner has asked it, and what it is the questioner's heart truly conceals. Under that gaze Wu Lie's various prepared speeches dissolved; what remained was nothing more than a bare fact: Jing Tong was dead. Zhao Ming was alive. Yun Suhua was alive. He himself remained. This was the entire reason he had come. Nothing more. Lady Silence's eyes are in truth the author's own eyes. The mirror figure here reflects not the face but the motive — beneath Wu Lie's desire for undying life lies a terror of loss he dare not name again. The commentator notes: what a person seeks is rarely what a person says; Lady Silence knows this truth first, and therefore questions him with silence.

A hero travels a thousand li to ask one question; by the time it reaches the lips, the meaning has already shifted.

The mirror holds no face — what then does it reflect? The word 'grief' is not yet spoken, yet the tears have already turned home.

無言君起身，不發一語，引吳烈穿行深殿之後，越數道無門之門，至一所在。其地無牆無頂，夜天壓低如帷，星辰在頭頂密密聚攏，大如拳石，近如可摘。地心有一潭，廣不過三丈，水色如鏡，深不可測。無風而水不動，水面映出星辰，與頭頂所見分毫不差，唯方向顛倒，彷彿兩個世界正以此水為界相望。吳烈立於潭邊，下望良久，忽覺心中舊事皆在水中重現——桃林之盟、朱華苑中的燈、璟同臨死之臉——皆清晰如刻，不曾因歲月而模糊半

Lady Silence rose and, without uttering a word, led Wu Lie through the deepest reaches of the hall, past several doorless doorways, to a certain place. There were no walls here, no ceiling; the night sky pressed low like a curtain, and the stars gathered thickly overhead, large as fist-stones, near enough to pluck. At the centre of the ground lay a pool, no wider than three zhang, its water mirror-coloured, its depth unplumbable. Without any wind, the water did not stir; the water's surface mirrored the stars above in precise correspondence, reversed in direction only, as though two worlds faced each other across this water as their boundary. Wu Lie stood at the pool's edge and looked down for a long time. Suddenly all the old events of his heart re-emerged in the water — the oath in the peach grove, the lamp in the Vermilion Garden, Jing Tong's face at the moment of dying — all of them clear as carving, not blurred even slightly by the passing of years.

無言君立於他身側，以手勢示意：此即不死之淵。語氣或有或無，聽者自行補足。吳烈問：「飲之果可不死？」無言君點首。吳烈再問：「代價幾何？」無言君這才開口，聲音低平如水底石，她說：「此水非贈，乃借。它從汝所愛之人的餘年中默取，不告知彼，不可贖回。汝之壽延一載，彼之命縮一載。汝飲一口，彼之燈減一寸油，彼不知，汝知。」吳烈立時沉默。無言君繼續道：「此外，不死者所得，非逃離悲苦，乃悲苦之永恆清醒——汝

天命輓歌

卷九

將目睹汝所愛之人一一老去，一一離世，而汝之記憶不會磨損，每一張面

十三

孔，每一句話，永遠鮮活如初見，永遠疼痛如初失。」

四字乃本回之膽也。「彼不知」

者，所愛之人蒙而不覺，其命縮而不知；「汝知」者，飲者獨負此罪，無人可訴，無處可解。此非懲罰，乃結構使然——愛即孤獨，不死即永孤。批者擱筆，不能復言。

Lady Silence stood at his side and indicated with a gesture: this is the Water of Undying. Whether her meaning was spoken aloud or remained unspoken, the listener supplied what was needed. Wu Lie asked: 'If one drinks it, can one truly not die?' Lady Silence inclined her head. Wu Lie asked again: 'What is the price?' Only then did Lady Silence open her mouth; her voice was low and level as a stone beneath water. She said: 'This water is not a gift — it is a loan. It draws in silence upon the remaining years of those whom you love. They are not informed; it cannot be redeemed. For every year your life is extended, their life is shortened by one year. For every mouthful you drink, their lamp loses a measure of oil. They will not know. You will know.' Wu Lie fell immediately silent. Lady Silence continued: 'Furthermore, what the undying one receives is not escape from grief and suffering, but grief's eternal, clear-eyed extension — you will watch those you love grow old one by one, depart one by one, and your memory will not wear down. Every face, every word spoken, will remain as vivid as the first meeting, as painful as the first loss, forever.'

These four characters are the courage of this entire chapter. 'They will not know' — the beloved are shielded in ignorance while their lives diminish unseen. 'You will know' — the drinker bears this guilt alone, with no one to confess to, no place of release. This is not punishment; it is the structure of the thing itself — to love is to be alone, and to be undying is to be alone forever. The commentator sets down the brush and cannot speak further.

不死之水照雙星，一借一還無聲行。

所愛燈油減一寸，飲者孤知天下驚。

記憶不磨刀不鈍，每逢忌日痛如生。

長生非壽是長刑，刑場無獄囚自成。

吳烈立於淵邊，不動，不言。無言君亦退三步，立於稍遠之處，不催，不議，只讓夜色靜靜圍籠。吳烈心中想起昭明。想起昭明在謀事時的神色——

天命輓歌

卷九

眉間一道淺紋，眼底一縷憂光，此後又要因他這個主公之故，再添幾許白

八十四

髮。他若飲此水，昭明之命便如燭焰，為他而縮。他又想起雲素華，想起她伏案之姿，想起她的簿冊，那些密密的字跡記錄著人世的一切，若她不在，那記錄便斷，世界的某一部分便無人見證。吳烈蹲下身，以指尖觸及水面。水涼，靜，如璟同最後的額頭。他縮回手。

The water of undying mirrors twin stars; the loan and the return are transacted without sound.
The beloved's lamp oil is lessened by one measure; the drinker alone knows, and the knowing
shakes the world.

Memory does not wear, the blade does not dull; each anniversary of loss is as painful as the first
dying.

Long life is not longevity — it is a long sentence; the execution ground has no prison, yet the
prisoner makes himself.

Wu Lie stood at the edge of the pool. He did not move; he did not speak. Lady Silence stepped
back three paces and stood a little further away — not hurrying him, not commenting, only letting
the night quietly enclose them. In his heart Wu Lie thought of Zhao Ming. He thought of Zhao
Ming's expression when planning — a faint crease between the brows, a thread of anxious light in
the depths of the eyes; from this point on, because of him, this lord of his, how many more white
hairs would appear. If Wu Lie drank this water, Zhao Ming's life would be like a candle flame,
shortened on his behalf. Then he thought of Yun Suhua: he thought of her bent over her desk, of
her ledgers, those densely written characters that recorded everything of the human world. If she
were gone, that record would break off; some portion of the world would go unwitnessed. Wu Lie
crouched down and touched the surface of the water with his fingertip. The water was cool and
still — like Jing Tong's forehead at the last.

第一日，吳烈坐於淵邊，未飲。無言君不在，然吳烈知她在某處，如山知天氣之在，不見而感得到。夜間星辰低移，水中星辰亦隨之低移，兩個天空緩緩旋轉，而潭水本身始終寂然如故。吳烈入眠，夢中見璟同，璟同站在桃林中，枝上無花，只剩枯木，璟同笑著說：「你來做什麼？」吳烈欲答，夢已散。

第二日，吳烈仍坐。他不飢，不渴，唯覺寒，然此寒並非風之所賜，乃靜之

所賜。靜到極處，人方能聽見平日被雜音遮蓋的東西——他聽見自己的心跳，聽見遠方雲素華執筆的聲音（此當然是幻，然他確乎聽見），聽見昭明某夜喃喃自語的謀算聲（亦是幻，然同樣清晰）。他坐在世界的盡頭，而世界仍在他的耳邊繼續，不曾因他的離開而停止一刻。這令他既感到被需要，又感到渺小。

The first day: Wu Lie sat beside the pool and did not drink. Lady Silence was not present, yet Wu Lie knew she was somewhere nearby — as a mountain knows the weather without seeing it. In the night the stars moved slowly lower; the stars in the water moved slowly lower with them; two skies turned at a measured pace, while the pool itself remained always as still as before. Wu Lie slept. In his dream he saw Jing Tong. Jing Tong stood in the peach grove; the branches bore no flowers, only bare wood. Jing Tong was smiling. He said: 'What have you come here to do?' Wu Lie tried to answer. The dream dissolved.

The second day: Wu Lie still sat. He was neither hungry nor thirsty, only cold — yet this cold was not the gift of wind but of stillness. When stillness reaches its extreme, a person begins to hear what ordinary noise has been covering: he heard his own heartbeat; he heard, from far away, the sound of Yun Suhua's brush moving on paper — which was of course hallucination, yet he heard it distinctly; he heard Zhao Ming murmuring calculations to himself on some night — also hallucination, yet equally clear. He sat at the world's farthest edge, and the world continued beside his ear, unceasing, not paused for even a moment by his departure. This made him feel needed and, simultaneously, very small.

第二日靜如無物，風不至，水不鳴。

素華筆聲傳萬里，昭明謀語入空庭。

皆是幻，皆是真，幻與真間何處停。

第三日，吳烈未動。黎明前，天與水之間那道界限幾乎消失，星辰上下皆同，分不清哪個是真實的天空，哪個是鏡中的倒影。吳烈就在這分不清的時刻，向無言君問出那個問題。他不回頭，對著潭水說：「世間可有什麼，是

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卷九

真正不必付代價的？」無言君的聲音從他身後傳來，仍是那個低平的聲調，八十六

不急不緩：「有。記憶。它耗費的是記憶者自身，而非被記憶者。」吳烈沉默，久之，他點頭，如一棵樹在無風的日子裡點頭，原因不可見，然動作確實發生。

此乃全書至此最要緊的一句話，亦是吳烈轉身之樞紐。不死之水奪人壽，記憶只耗自身——故記憶非剝削，而是

一種孤獨的尊嚴。吳烈聽此一語，知環同之死不可逆，然環同之存在，可以靠他自己來承擔，無需向他人借。批者以為，此句亦是

作者對讀者的囑咐：請記住你所愛的人，以你自己的代價，而非他們的。

The second day, still as if nothing existed — no wind arrived, the water made no sound.

Suhua's brush-sound carries ten thousand li; Zhao Ming's planning-words enter the empty courtyard.

All hallucination; all true — between hallucination and truth, where does one rest?

The third day: Wu Lie had not moved. Before dawn, the boundary between sky and water nearly vanished; stars above and below were the same, and one could not distinguish which was the true sky and which was the reflection in the mirror. It was in this moment of indistinction that Wu Lie spoke his question to Lady Silence. He did not turn around; he addressed the pool: 'Is there anything in the world that truly costs nothing?' Lady Silence's voice came from behind him, still in that low and level tone, neither hurried nor slow: 'There is. Memory. It costs the one who remembers — not the one who is remembered.' Wu Lie was silent. After a long time, he nodded — as a tree nods on a windless day, the cause invisible, yet the movement unmistakably real. This is the most essential sentence in the book to this point, and the pivot on which Wu Lie turns homeward. The Water of Undying takes another's years; memory costs only oneself — and so memory is not predation but a solitary dignity. Hearing this single sentence, Wu Lie understands that Jing Tong's death cannot be reversed, yet Jing Tong's existence is something he himself can bear — without borrowing from another. The commentator believes this sentence is also the author's instruction to the reader: remember those you love, at your own cost, not theirs.

三日淵邊未沾唇，星沉星起見無痕。

不死之水非不死，只是悲苦換長春。

玄母一語輕如水，重過千山壓此身。

英雄轉身向來路，身後淵中仍照人。

吳烈起身，拂衣，未回頭再看那潭水。無言君立於他身後三步，他對她行一揖，言辭簡短：「承蒙指引。」無言君低首，算是答禮，仍不多言。吳烈轉

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卷九

走出那無頂之地，走回深殿，走過無門之門，步伐較來時穩了些，非因

八十七

輕鬆，乃因心中有了去向。他所揹負的並未減輕——環同之死仍在，然那重量如今有了形狀，他知道如何攜帶它，不必飲水，不必借別人的命，只需一步步，用自己的腳，走回尚有昭明與雲素華的地方去。

Three days beside the pool and his lips were never wetted; stars sank and stars rose and left no mark.

The water that will not die is not undying — it only exchanges grief for an extended spring.

Lady Silence speaks one phrase, light as water; it weighs heavier than a thousand mountains upon this body.

The hero turns and faces the road home; behind him, in the pool, the water still holds a reflection of a man.

Wu Lie stood up, smoothed his garments, and did not look back at the pool. Lady Silence stood three paces behind him; he made a bow toward her and spoke briefly: 'I am grateful for the guidance.' Lady Silence inclined her head in acknowledgement, still saying nothing further. Wu Lie turned and walked out of that roofless place, back through the innermost hall, back through the doorless doors. His step was somewhat steadier than when he had arrived — not because he was lighter, but because his heart now had a direction. What he carried had not lessened — Jing Tong's death was still there — yet that weight had acquired a shape. He knew now how to carry it: without drinking the water, without borrowing another's life, only step by step, on his own feet, walking back toward the place where Zhao Ming and Yun Suhua still were.

此後無言君獨立殿中，四壁幽藍如故，不死之淵亦如故，星辰在水中顛倒如故。她已見過無數來者，有飲而後悔者，有飲而忘悔者，有如吳烈般三日不飲、轉身而去者——然此最後一類，寥寥無幾。她不知吳烈此後命途如何，天命之事，連玄都之主亦不能逆觀。然她知一事：此人來時帶著一個問題，去時帶著一個答案；答案非她所給，乃他自潭水三日之靜中，自己取得。欲知後事如何，且看下回分解。正是：悲者未必求死，求死者未必悲；三日不

Afterward Lady Silence stood alone in the hall. The deep-blue luminescence of the four walls remained as before; the Water of Undying remained as before; the stars upended in the water remained as before. She had seen numberless petitioners come: some who drank and then repented; some who drank and forgot repentance; some like Wu Lie who for three days did not drink and then turned and departed — yet this last kind was very rare. She did not know what road Wu Lie's fate would take from here; in matters of Heaven's Mandate, not even the ruler of the Dark Metropolis could see backward from the end. Yet she knew one thing: this man had arrived carrying a question, and departed carrying an answer. The answer was not hers to give — he had drawn it himself, from three days of stillness beside the pool. As for what happened next, the following chapter will reveal all. As it truly is: the one in grief does not necessarily seek death; the one who seeks death is not necessarily in grief. Three days beside the water, undrinking — only then does this life begin to know its own flavour.

第十回 朱華傾顏 輓歌一夢

朱華傾顏人未盡

天命輓歌夢難終

卻說吳烈辭卻不死之水，踏上歸途，此去非昔日旌旗出征之路，乃一人一劍，寂然徐行。初時山道荒僻，草木猶帶兵燹之氣，焦土殘垣，入目皆是。

然行過三日，地勢漸低，水聲漸聞，路旁忽見一株野梅，斜生於岩縫之中，

天命輓歌

卷十

枝條細如女子手腕，花卻開得極盛，白若積雪，香氣撲人。吳烈駐足良久，

八十九

不知何故，眼眶微熱。他去時不曾留意此樹，此刻回望，方知天下間原有此等物事，靜靜存在，不為英雄而開，亦不為英雄而謝。

CHAPTER 10: THE VERMILION GARDEN FALLS; THE ELEGY, A SINGLE DREAM

The Vermilion Garden falls yet none are finished

The Elegy of the Mandate — the dream will not end

So Wu Lie refused the Water of Undying and turned toward home. This road was not the road of banners and drums on which he had departed; he walked it alone, sword at his side, in unhurried silence. In the first days the mountain path was desolate, the trees and grass still bearing the smell of war-fire, scorched earth and broken walls meeting the eye at every turn. Yet after three days the terrain gradually descended, the sound of water became audible, and suddenly by the roadside he saw a wild plum tree growing aslant from a crack in the rock. Its branches were fine as a woman's wrist, yet its flowers bloomed with extraordinary fullness — white as accumulated snow, the fragrance striking him as he passed. Wu Lie stood still for a long while. He did not know why, but his eyes grew faintly warm. He had not noticed this tree when he went out. Looking back at it now, he understood for the first time that the world contained such things: existing quietly, blooming not for heroes, and fading not for heroes.

去時不見梅一株，歸來方識白花孤。

征途殺氣蔽天眼，此花開落無人知。

岸上漁童垂釣坐，暮煙一縷起茅廬。

英雄眼底多血色，幾曾識得尋常居。

又行數日，漸近永邑地界。路旁農舍炊煙嫋嫋，黃昏時分一婦人倚門而望，手中握著尚未縫完的布鞋，神情悵然，顯是在等人。吳烈擦肩而過，二人目

天命輓歌

光緒二十九年

一瞬，婦人眼中有一種吳烈看不懂、卻忽然懂得的東西。他想起環

九十

同，想起環同在朱華苑中以指尖輕觸朱槿的那個傍晚。那雙粗礪的手，比眼前婦人手中的布鞋更不懂得柔軟，卻也是以同樣茫然的善意，試著去摸索這個世界中他所不識的溫柔。吳烈腳步一緩，然而他終於沒有停下，只是低頭，繼續往前走。

此「茫然」二字，批者以為全書環同之寫照。環同非不仁，乃不解仁為何物而仁者也。

吳烈至此方悟，悟時人已不在，此世間最痛之遲。

Going out he did not see this single plum; returning, he at last perceives the solitary white bloom.
The killing air of the campaign road had sealed his eyes to heaven — this flower opened and fell
with no one to know.

On the bank a fishing child sits with his line; a thread of dusk smoke rises from a thatched
dwelling.

A hero's eyes are so long filled with blood-colour — how many times has he ever perceived the
ordinary dwelling?

After several more days he drew near the territory of Yong. By the roadside a farmhouse trailed
cooking smoke into the air; at dusk a woman leaned against the doorframe looking out, holding in
her hands a cloth shoe not yet finished, her expression distant — clearly waiting for someone. Wu
Lie passed close by her; their gazes crossed for one instant. In the woman's eyes there was
something Wu Lie could not read, yet suddenly understood. He thought of Jing Tong — of the
evening in the Vermilion Garden when Jing Tong touched a red hibiscus with his fingertip. Those
rough, coarse hands knew even less of softness than the cloth shoe in this woman's hands, and yet
they reached toward what was tender in the world with the same bewildered goodwill, trying to
feel their way. Wu Lie's steps slowed. Yet in the end he did not stop; he only lowered his head
slightly and walked on. 'Bewildered goodwill' — the commentator takes these words as the portrait of Jing Tong
throughout the entire book. Jing Tong was not without humanity; he was humane without knowing what humanity
was. Wu Lie only understands this now, when the person is already gone. This is the world's most agonising lateness.

永邑城門入目之時，吳烈立於官道之上，凝視良久。城牆較昔日低矮了——非城牆真有傾頹，乃他目光已改。昔日出征，城牆在他眼中乃天下之固，萬夫之障；今日歸來，不過是一堵舊石牆，縫隙間生著雜草，城頭旗幟褪色，守卒倚矛而立，神情疲憊。入城之後，所見更非昔日氣象：東市門可羅雀，幾家鋪面已然關門，牌匾積塵；舊日熱鬧的酒肆，如今窗紙破洞，隱隱飄出酸腐之味。有老者坐於階前，見吳烈過，拱手曰：「主公回矣。」語氣平

天命輓歌



婢道一句尋常天氣，並無驚喜，亦無怨怒。

When the gates of Yong came into view, Wu Lie stood on the main road and gazed for a long while. The walls looked lower than before — not that the walls had truly fallen, but that his eyes had changed. When he set out on campaign, those walls had seemed to him the firmness of the world, the barrier of ten thousand men; returning now, they were merely an old stone wall with weeds growing in the cracks, banners faded at the battlements, guards leaning on their spears with exhausted faces. Once inside the city, what he saw was far from the sight of former days: the Eastern Market was all but deserted, several storefronts had already closed, their plaques thick with dust; the lively wine-house of old now had torn paper in its windows, giving off a faint smell of sourness and rot. An old man sat on a doorstep; seeing Wu Lie pass, he raised his hands in salute and said: 'My lord has returned.' His tone was flat — the way one remarks on ordinary weather — with neither surprise nor resentment.

府中情形，昭明早已差人稟報過大略，然親眼所見，又是另一番滋味。長子陣亡於第三年之戰，次子失蹤於渡河之役，老父自吳烈出征後不久便臥病，輾轉兩載，於去冬辭世，入土時連送葬的族人都湊不齊。府中侍從散去大半，廊柱之漆已見龜裂，院中花草無人修剪，野蔓悄悄爬上了牆角。偏廳之中，吳烈昔日懸掛地圖的牆面如今只餘幾個釘孔，地圖早已不知去向。昭明獨自坐於廳中，見吳烈入，緩緩起身，二人相對，皆未言語，只是站了很長

廊柱龜裂漆半脫，庭草無人委露華。
昔年地圖今何在，牆上唯餘幾釘疤。
昭明白鬢添三縷，吳烈鐵面現風沙。
二人相對無一語，秋風替道別離話。

Zhao Ming had long since sent word ahead of the general situation in the manor, yet seeing it with his own eyes was another flavour entirely. The eldest son had died in battle in the third year of the war; the second son had vanished in the river-crossing campaign; the old patriarch had fallen ill not long after Wu Lie's departure, lingered two difficult years, and passed away last winter — at his burial they could not even gather enough clan members for a proper funeral procession. More than half the household servants had dispersed; the lacquer on the corridor pillars had begun to crack and peel; the flowers and plants in the courtyard had no one to trim them, and wild vines had crept quietly up the corners of the walls. In the side hall where Wu Lie had once hung his campaign maps, nothing remained but a few nail-holes — the maps had long since disappeared, no one knew where. Zhao Ming sat alone in the hall. When he saw Wu Lie enter, he rose slowly. The two men faced each other, neither speaking, standing thus for a very long time.

The corridor pillars crack, their lacquer half-peeled away; the courtyard grass, untended, is weighed down with dew.

The campaign maps of former years — where are they now? On the wall nothing remains but the scars of nails.

Three more strands of white have appeared at Zhao Ming's temples; Wu Lie's iron face shows the wind and sand of years.

The two men face each other with not a single word; the autumn wind speaks in their stead the words of parting.

天命璽之事，昭明早有安排。霧胤竊璽之後，昭明暗中遣人追蹤，費時三載，輾轉尋回，彼時霧胤已死於亂軍之中，璽落於一廢棄宗廟的神龕之後，蒙塵已深。歸璽之典，設於府中正堂，昭明邀本地耆老數人觀禮，其餘並無鋪張。吳烈雙手接過玉璽，不如想象中之沉，亦不如想象中之輕，只是一塊玉，幽黑而冷，如同握著一個已經說完的故事。眾人皆肅然，然無人歡呼，無人落淚，唯昭明低頭看著玉璽良久，輕聲曰：「刻紋似乎淡了。」吳烈俯

天命輓歌

首細看

，果見璽面山河之紋，昔年聽聞時說是清晰如刀刻，如今卻朦朧若霧

九十三

中遠山，細辨之下，方能隱約識得。

璽紋淡矣而天命猶在，是謂天命從來非物，乃讀物者所賦也。作

者於此借昭明一語，藏全書之哲——璽存而紋滅，人在而義散，此非悲劇，乃天地之常。批者至此，不知哭笑。

Regarding the Jade Seal of Heaven's Mandate, Zhao Ming had made arrangements long before. After Wu Yin stole the Seal, Zhao Ming had quietly dispatched men to track it; it had taken three years of circuitous pursuit to recover it. By then Wu Yin had died in the chaos of battle, and the Seal had come to rest behind the shrine niche of an abandoned ancestral temple, buried deep in dust. The ceremony of the Seal's return was held in the main hall of the manor; Zhao Ming invited a few of the local elders to observe, and there was no further ostentation. Wu Lie received the jade seal in both hands. It was not as heavy as he had imagined, nor as light. It was simply a piece of jade — dim black and cold — as though he were holding a story that had already been told to its conclusion. Everyone present fell into reverent silence, yet no one cheered and no one wept. Only Zhao Ming bowed his head and studied the Seal for a long while, then said softly: 'The inscribed pattern seems to have faded.' Wu Lie leaned close and looked carefully. Indeed — the mountain-and-river engraving on the Seal's face, which had once been described as clear as knife-cut lines, now appeared hazy as distant peaks in fog. Only by fine scrutiny could one make out the pattern at all. The seal's inscription fades yet the Mandate endures — meaning that the Mandate was never the object itself, but what those who read it chose to confer. The author hides the philosophy of the whole book in a single sentence of Zhao Ming's: the seal remains but the pattern is gone, the person survives but the meaning has dispersed. This is not tragedy — it is the ordinary condition of heaven and earth. The commentator, arriving here, cannot say whether to weep or laugh.

昭明沉默片刻，方曰：「天命，本是讀之事。」吳烈將玉璽放回錦盒之中，錦盒蓋下，室中忽然安靜得像一口廢井。耆老們陸續告辭，腳步聲漸遠。昭明看著吳烈，臉上有一種吳烈從未在他臉上見過的神情——非悲，非喜，乃是一種已看透而仍然不語的默然，如同一棵在深秋中獨自落葉的老樹，知道春天或許還會來，卻不再為此振奮。二人又對坐了一個時辰，未曾燃燈，暮色漸深，堂中唯餘兩個輪廓，相對而坐，如兩座空山。

Zhao Ming was silent for a moment, then said: 'The Mandate of Heaven has always been, in the end, a matter of reading.' Wu Lie set the jade seal back into its brocade box. When the lid came down, the room fell suddenly quiet as an abandoned well. The elders took their leave one by one, their footsteps growing distant. Zhao Ming looked at Wu Lie, and on his face was an expression Wu Lie had never seen there before — neither grief nor joy, but a kind of silent composure that had seen through everything and still declined to speak, like an old tree in deep autumn shedding its leaves alone, knowing that spring might come again yet no longer stirred by the thought. The two men sat facing each other for another hour without lighting a lamp. The dusk deepened. In the hall there remained only two silhouettes, seated facing each other, like two empty mountains.

分明已有花苞，細如芥子，緊緊閉合，蓄而待放。吳烈伸手，以指腹輕

幹若虯龍，此刻樹葉盡脫，每一根枝條都清晰可見，枯褐交錯，然枝梢之觸其中一粒，冰涼，堅實，尚未開放，卻已然在此。

荷池殘葉浮秋水，竹徑新篁映曉霧。

殘菊三朵寒露顫，古梅枝頭蓄未吐。

英雄以指觸花苞，冷而未開已在處。

此苑傾頽非傾頽，含苞之意尚如故。

The next morning, Wu Lie went alone to the Vermilion Garden. The garden gate stood half-open; he pushed through and entered. The scene in the courtyard stopped his feet: the lotus pond remained, but the lotus leaves had withered, scorched yellow and curled, floating on the surface like old letters soaked in ink. Along the bamboo path, half the stalks had yellowed and died, yet a few new canes grew among them, slender and upright, showing a faint tinge of green in the morning mist. In the chrysanthemum beds three or four late blooms still persisted; it was deep autumn, and they had opened late, and so had not yet fully faded — pale-yellow petals trembling slightly in the cold dew. What moved Wu Lie most was the ancient plum tree. Three hundred years old, its trunk twisted like a coiling dragon: now every leaf had fallen, every branch stood clear and visible, a crossing of dry brown; yet at the tips of the branches, unmistakably, flower buds had already formed — fine as mustard seeds, tightly shut, gathering themselves, waiting to open. Wu Lie reached out and touched one with the pad of his finger. Cold. Solid. Not yet open — yet already here.

Remnant lotus leaves float on the autumn pond; new bamboo along the path catches the morning mist.

Three late chrysanthemums tremble in the cold dew; at the ancient plum's branch-tips, buds gather and wait.

The hero touches a bud with one finger — cold, not yet open, and already here.

This garden falls yet does not fall; the intent of gathered buds remains as it always was.

苑深處有一閣，名曰「聽雨閣」，吳烈昔年甚少至此，今日循小徑而入，見閣門虛掩，輕叩，有聲自內應曰：「請進。」推門而見，雲素華端坐案前，案上鋪陳書冊，筆墨俱在，猶如往日一般，唯她面色較昔更為蒼白，眉間隱有憔悴之色，咳疾未愈，以帕掩口，咳罷，方起身行禮。吳烈見狀，攬她重坐，自己於對面坐下，兩人相對。屋外柿樹一株，秋深葉落，唯剩橘紅柿子掛於枝頭，燦若燈盞，透過窗櫺投下暖色的光影。吳烈看著她案上那些厚厚

Deep in the garden was a pavilion called the Rain-Listening Pavilion. Wu Lie had rarely come here in former years; today he followed the small path to it and found the door standing ajar. He knocked lightly; a voice answered from within: 'Please enter.' He pushed the door open and saw Yun Suhua seated upright at her writing desk, the desk spread with ledgers and books, brush and ink all in place — just as in former days — except that her complexion was paler than before, with a look of weariness in her brow. Her consumptive cough had not healed; she covered her mouth with a handkerchief, and when the coughing passed she rose to offer her greeting. Seeing this, Wu Lie ushered her back to her seat and sat down himself on the opposite side. The two of them faced each other. Outside the window stood a persimmon tree; deep autumn, its leaves fallen, leaving only orange-red persimmons hanging at the branch-tips, bright as lanterns, casting warm-coloured light and shadow through the lattice. Wu Lie looked at those thick ledgers stacked on her desk, was silent for a long moment, then opened his mouth and said: 'Tell me everything that happened while I was gone.'

雲素華聞言，以手撫書冊，低首片刻，抬眼望向吳烈。她說：「主公，這些書冊，所記皆是您離去之後苑中諸事，然而——」她頓了一頓，「其實不止苑中。我記下了璟同兄弟的死訊傳至苑中的那個下午，苑中如何忽然靜了。

我記下了昭明先生每次入苑、於古梅樹下獨坐多久、何時起身、臉上是何神色。我記下了玉璽失蹤之夜，柿樹上的熟柿無故跌落了七枚，聲音悶響，一夜不停。我記下了每一場雨，每一次花開花謝，每一個沒有回來的人的名

天命輓歌

卷十一

只要我知道的。」她說到此處，聲音細如蠶絲，又頓了很長一頓，方續

九十七

道：「主公，我不知道這算不算一部書，也不知道有誰會讀它。我只是不願意讓這一切，死得太乾淨。」

此一語，乃全書之鑰，亦批者之所以批書之緣也。英雄死而輓歌存，輓歌存

而英雄未死，此素華之大志，非兒女私情，乃以一身之病軀，擔天下之記憶。讀者至此，可知全書實為素華所著，吾輩不過後來之

讀者耳。謹此一拜，送諸君離書。

Hearing this, Yun Suhua laid her hand on the ledgers and bowed her head for a moment, then raised her eyes to look at Wu Lie. She said: 'My lord, these ledgers record the affairs of the garden after your departure — yet —' She paused. 'In truth, they record more than the garden. I wrote down the afternoon the news of sworn-brother Jing Tong's death reached the garden — how the garden suddenly fell quiet. I wrote down each time Zhao Ming entered the garden, how long he sat alone under the ancient plum, when he rose, what expression was on his face when he did. I wrote down the night the Jade Seal went missing — how seven ripe persimmons fell from the tree for no reason, making a muffled sound throughout the night without stopping. I wrote down every rain, every time a flower opened or fell, and the name of every person who did not come back — every name I knew.' Her voice by now was as fine as a silkworm's thread. After a very long pause, she continued: 'My lord, I do not know whether this counts as a book, nor whether anyone will ever read it. I only could not bear for all of this to die too cleanly.' This single utterance is the key to the entire book, and the reason the commentator has written these notes at all. Heroes die and the elegy survives; while the elegy survives, the heroes have not died. This is Suhua's great ambition — not a woman's private sentiment, but the bearing, in one ailing body, of the world's memory. Readers who arrive here may now understand that the whole book was written by Suhua, and we are nothing but the later readers. With this, I bow once — and bid you farewell from the book.

吳烈聽完，久久無言。窗外柿樹的光影移了又移，日色漸斜。他終於開口，聲音沙啞，非哭，然似哭：「那麼，璟同——在你書中，他是怎樣的？」雲素華略一沉吟，翻開一冊，找到某頁，輕輕唸道：「璟同兄弟，入苑凡十七次，每次必至古梅樹下，以手撫幹，停留少則片刻，多則半個時辰。問其何故，答曰：『此樹比我年長二百歲，它見過的事，我不懂；然它見過，即是見過了。』」她唸完，合上書，望著吳烈。吳烈低頭，以手背遮臉，許久，

天命輓歌

抬頭

卷十

眼眶微紅，笑了一笑，說：「是他說的話。」二人皆不再說什麼，唯

十八

聽柿樹的葉子在風中細細作聲，如竊竊私語，說著他們說不出口的話。

柿燈照窗光自暖，素華病骨執筆端。

天命璽紋朦朧矣，朱華苑草蔓生寒。

英雄去路無回頭，書冊留痕是別岸。

一樹古梅蓄未吐，春來或開或不還。

Wu Lie listened until she finished, and then was silent for a long time. The light and shadow from the persimmon tree outside the window shifted and shifted; the sun's angle grew lower. At last he spoke, his voice rough — not weeping, yet resembling it: 'Then Jing Tong — in your book, what is he like?' Yun Suhua considered for a moment, opened a ledger, found a certain page, and read softly: 'Sworn-brother Jing Tong visited the garden on seventeen occasions; each time he invariably went to the ancient plum tree and placed his hand upon the trunk, remaining there anywhere from a brief moment to half an hour. When asked why, he answered: 「This tree is two hundred years my elder; the things it has seen, I do not understand — yet it has seen them, and that means they have been seen.」' She finished reading, closed the book, and looked at Wu Lie. Wu Lie bowed his head and covered his face with the back of his hand. After a long time, he raised his head; his eyes were faintly red. He smiled and said: 'Those are his words.' Neither of them spoke anything further. They only listened to the leaves of the persimmon tree making a fine sound in the wind — like whispered confidences, saying the things they could not say aloud.

Persimmon lanterns warm the window from without; Suhua's ailing hand holds the brush upright. The Mandate Seal's inscription has grown hazy; the Vermilion Garden's grass spreads cold and untended.

The hero's road out admits no turning back; the traces in the ledger are the other shore.

An ancient plum gathers its buds, not yet open — when spring comes, it may bloom, or may not return.

自此，吳烈不再問天下事，亦不再問兵戈之事，唯間或入朱華苑，與雲素華同坐，或聽她讀舊冊，或二人同在古梅樹下，各自無言。昭明仍在府中料理舊務，白髮漸多，然目光猶清，偶爾談及時局，語氣平靜如談天氣，似乎一切皆在意料之內，又似乎一切皆在意料之外。天命璽安置於庫中，無人議及再用，亦無人議及銷毀，唯任其靜靜存在，如一個已無人記得起源的習俗，因慣性而延續。永邑城漸漸在廢墟之上生長出某種新的秩序，緩慢，粗糙，

天命輓歌
然活著。

雲素華的書冊日益增厚，咳疾卻也日益深重，她從不提及此事，吳

九十九

烈亦從不問，二人皆知，書冊寫完之日，或許便是她的離去之時，然此事既非她所悲，亦非他所懼，乃天地間事，如古梅花開花落，自有其時。

From that time forward, Wu Lie no longer asked about affairs under heaven, nor about matters of weapons and war. He would enter the Vermilion Garden from time to time, sit together with Yun Suhua, either listening to her read from the old ledgers or sitting together beneath the ancient plum tree, each in their own silence. Zhao Ming remained in the manor managing old affairs; his white hair continued to spread, yet his eyes remained clear. When he occasionally spoke of the current situation, his tone was as calm as if discussing the weather — as though everything had been within expectation, and as though nothing had been. The Jade Seal was placed in the treasury; no one discussed using it again, nor did anyone discuss destroying it; it was simply allowed to exist quietly, like a custom whose origin no one remembered any longer, continuing by force of habit. The city of Yong slowly grew a new kind of order from its ruins — slow, rough, yet alive. Yun Suhua's ledgers grew thicker by the day, and her consumptive illness grew deeper by the day; she never mentioned this, and Wu Lie never asked. Both knew: the day the ledgers were completed would perhaps be the day of her departure. Yet this was neither her sorrow nor his fear; it was a matter of heaven and earth — like the ancient plum tree blooming and shedding its blossoms, each at its appointed time.

問曰：天命屬誰手？

答曰：璽紋已朦朧，天下難分曉。

問曰：璟同今何在？

答曰：書冊留其名，古梅記其好。

問曰：輓歌為誰唱？

答曰：素華執筆端，吳烈聽至老。

萬古大河東流去，英雄掩面各傷悼。

天命輓歌

卷十

天命輓歌一夢醒，朱華苑中秋意早。

昭明白首問星河，璟同野魂入草道。

霧胤骸骨化黃塵，玉璽紋跡誰能考。

萬古大河東流去，英雄掩面各傷悼。

素華合卷燈漸滅，此書從此無後稿。

天命輓歌即此夢，夢中諸人皆草草。

萬古大河東流去，英雄掩面各傷悼。

One asks: in whose hand does Heaven's Mandate rest?

The answer: the seal's inscription has grown hazy; the realm is hard to read.

One asks: where is Jing Tong now?

The answer: the ledger preserves his name; the ancient plum remembers what he loved.

One asks: for whom is the elegy sung?

The answer: Suhua holds the brush upright; Wu Lie listens until he grows old.

Ten thousand ages the great river flows eastward; heroes cover their faces and grieve, each alone.

The Elegy of the Mandate — a single dream — one wakes; in the Vermilion Garden, autumn comes early.

Zhao Ming, white-haired, questions the river of stars; Jing Tong's wild soul enters the grass-path.

Wu Yin's bones have turned to yellow dust; who can now study the jade seal's traced pattern?

Ten thousand ages the great river flows eastward; heroes cover their faces and grieve, each alone.

Suhua closes the final ledger; the lamp grows dim; from this moment the book has no further draft.

The Elegy of the Mandate is this very dream; within the dream all persons pass like grass.

Ten thousand ages the great river flows eastward; heroes cover their faces and grieve, each alone.

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